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The Implications of News Deserts for Central India – Interviewing Local Content Producers



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Economics and Political Science**

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My sincere thanks to the people of Bastar, whose stories and resilience have been the heart of this research. Their strength and experiences over the past 50 years have profoundly shaped this study, and I am honoured to have had the opportunity to learn from you.

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I extend my sincere thanks to the people of Bastar, whose stories and resilience have been the heart of this research. Your strength and experiences over the past 50 years have profoundly shaped this study, and I am honoured to have had the opportunity to learn from you.

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Abstract

This dissertation investigates the implications of news deserts in Central India by examining the experiences of local content producers in Bastar, a region largely underrepresented in mainstream media. Despite a significant number of media outlets, key issues such as the socio-political conflict of Naxalism receive minimal coverage, highlighting a paradox of presence without substance in these news deserts. This study addresses the research question: How do local journalists perceive their roles and navigate the challenges of reporting in such underreported regions? Using episodic interviews with 14 journalists and thematic analysis, three global themes emerged: Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert, Challenges in Bridging the News Desert, and Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas. The findings reveal that journalists view their work as a civic duty, balancing advocacy with objectivity while facing severe financial, logistical, and safety challenges. This study contributes to the understanding of media dynamics in conflict zones by highlighting the dual roles of journalists as both reporters and community advocates. It also underscores the need for policy interventions that support editorial independence and financial stability to enhance news coverage in underserved areas, thereby fostering a more informed and engaged public.

Keywords: News Deserts, Local Journalism, Central India, Media Representation, Qualitative Research, Episodic Interviews, Thematic Analysis, Journalistic Ethics, Media Policy, Public Discourse.

Table of Contents

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT	3
ABSTRACT.....	4
1. INTRODUCTION	7
2. LITERATURE REVIEW	11
2.1 NEWS DESERTS	11
2.2 MEDIA LANDSCAPES IN ECONOMICALLY DEPRIVED REGIONS	12
2.3 CHALLENGES FACED BY JOURNALISTS IN CONFLICT ZONES	13
2.4 VIOLENCE AND INTIMIDATION	14
2.5 LIMITED ACCESS TO INFORMATION	15
2.6 STRATEGIES EMPLOYED BY LOCAL JOURNALISTS.....	15
2.7 ROLE OF LOCAL CONTENT PRODUCERS IN ADDRESSING NEWS DESERTS.....	16
2.8 METHODOLOGY	17
2.8.1 SITUATING THE METHODOLOGY WITHIN EXISTING RESEARCH	17
2.8.2 COMPARISON WITH OTHER METHODS	17
2.8.3 DISCUSSING METHODOLOGICAL TRENDS IN THE FIELD.....	18
3. METHODOLOGY:	20
3.1 COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS AND METHODOLOGY.....	20
3.2 PARTICIPANT SELECTION	22
3.3 RECRUITMENT PROCESS.....	22
3.4 DATA COLLECTION METHODS.....	23
3.5 POSITIONALITY AND RESEARCHER REFLEXIVITY.....	23
3.6 TRANSCRIPTION AND DATA MANAGEMENT	24
3.7 ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS.....	24
3.8 DATA ANALYSIS.....	25
3.8.1 THEMATIC ANALYSIS.....	25
3.8.2 EPISODIC ANALYSIS	25
4. FINDINGS.....	26
4.1 INTRODUCTION TO FINDINGS	26
FIGURE-1.....	27

4.2 OVERVIEW OF GLOBAL THEMES	27
4.3 GLOBAL THEME 1: BOUNDARY-SPANNING ROLES IN A NEWS DESERT.....	29
4.3.1 ORGANIZING THEME: PERCEPTION OF THEIR ROLE	31
4.3.2 ORGANIZING THEME: TASK DEFINITION AND RESPONSIBILITIES	32
4.4 GLOBAL THEME 2: CHALLENGES IN BRIDGING THE NEWS DESERT	33
4.4.1 ORGANIZING THEME 2.1: LOGISTICAL CHALLENGES.....	34
4.4.2 ORGANIZING THEME: FINANCIAL AND OPERATIONAL CONSTRAINTS	35
4.5 GLOBAL THEME 3: EDITORIAL AND ETHICAL DILEMMAS	37
4.5.1 ORGANIZING THEME: EDITORIAL AUTONOMY.....	38
4.5.2 ORGANIZING THEME: MEDIA LITERACY AND REPRESENTATION	39
4.6 SUMMARY OF FINDINGS	40
 <u>5. DISCUSSION:.....</u>	 <u>41</u>
 5.1 COMPARE AND CONTRAST WITH EXISTING LITERATURE	 41
5.1.1 ALIGNMENT WITH EXISTING LITERATURE	41
5.1.2 NEW INSIGHTS AND DIVERGENCES FROM EXISTING LITERATURE.....	42
5.1.3 CHALLENGES TO EXISTING THEORIES	43
 <u>6.0 CONCLUSION</u>	 <u>43</u>
 6.1 LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY	 43
6.2 FUTURE RESEARCH DIRECTIONS	44
6.3. KEY LEARNINGS AND CONTRIBUTIONS	45
5.6 CONCLUSION OF THE DISCUSSION SECTION	45
 <u>7. BIBLIOGRAPHY</u>	 <u>46</u>
 7.1 APPENDIX A- PARTICIPANT INFORMATION.....	 48
7.2 APPENDIX B- CONSENT FORM.....	49
7.3 APPENDIX C- RECRUITMENT MESSAGE	51
INTRODUCTION (5 MINUTES).....	51
SECTION 1: BACKGROUND AND ROLE (10 MINUTES)	51
SECTION 2: UNDERSTANDING AND DEFINING THEIR TASK (15 MINUTES).....	52
SECTION 3: SPECIFIC EPISODES AND THEIR SIGNIFICANCE (20 MINUTES).....	52
SECTION 4: REFLECTIONS ON THE BROADER MEDIA LANDSCAPE (15 MINUTES).....	52
SECTION 5: LOOKING FORWARD (5 MINUTES).....	53
CLOSING (5 MINUTES).....	53
7.5 APPENDIX E- CODE BOOK	53
7.6 APPENDIX F- DATA STRUCTURE	58
7.6 APPENDIX- G INTERVIEW TRANSCRIPT (FULL).....	59
7.7 APPENDIX- H – CHART.....	122
KEY OBSERVATIONS:	122

1. Introduction

“It is a structural problem. Our communication platforms are far too dependent on the people who burn houses, and not on those whose houses are burnt. - Shubhranshu Choudhary, Let’s Call Him Vasu”

Across the world, news deserts—regions where residents have limited access to credible news—are expanding, raising concerns about informed citizenship and the vitality of local democracies. In India, Chhattisgarh presents a striking example of this phenomenon, where, despite a considerable number of media outlets, critical regional issues remain underreported. This paradox is particularly evident in the coverage of Naxalism, a socio-political conflict that has significantly impacted the region but receives minimal attention in both local and national media.

To illustrate this point, Figure 1 (GSDP FY 2022 vs. Number of Registered Newspapers) shows Chhattisgarh as an economically weak region with fewer registered newspapers compared to states with higher economic output. This limited media representation is further evidenced by the relative frequency analysis using Factiva, which reveals that 'Bastar,' a district in Chhattisgarh heavily affected by Naxalism, appeared only about 0.1 times for every 100 occurrences of 'the' in three major English daily newspapers—The Hindu, Times of India, and Hindustan Times—over the past five years (Factiva, 2024). This suggests a significant information scarcity and aligns with the characteristics of a news desert, where communities lack access to comprehensive news coverage (Centre for Innovation & Sustainability in Local Media, 2019).

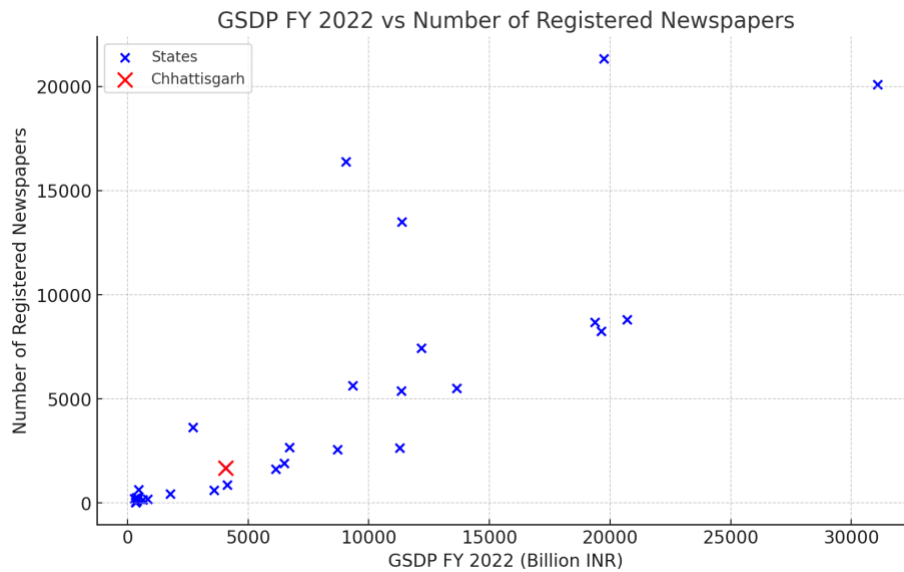


Figure-1

Additionally, the comparison of Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) with the number of FM stations shows that states with higher economic output generally have more FM stations. This trend, although not statistically significant, suggests an uneven distribution of media resources that contributes to the formation of news deserts. Furthermore, the state-run All India Radio, the only state-run radio service permitted to broadcast news, does not provide any news in Gondi, despite there being approximately 3 million Gondi speakers in the region, according to the 2001 census (Choudhary, 2012, p. 172).

Correlation Heatmap: GSDP, FM Stations, and Registered Publications

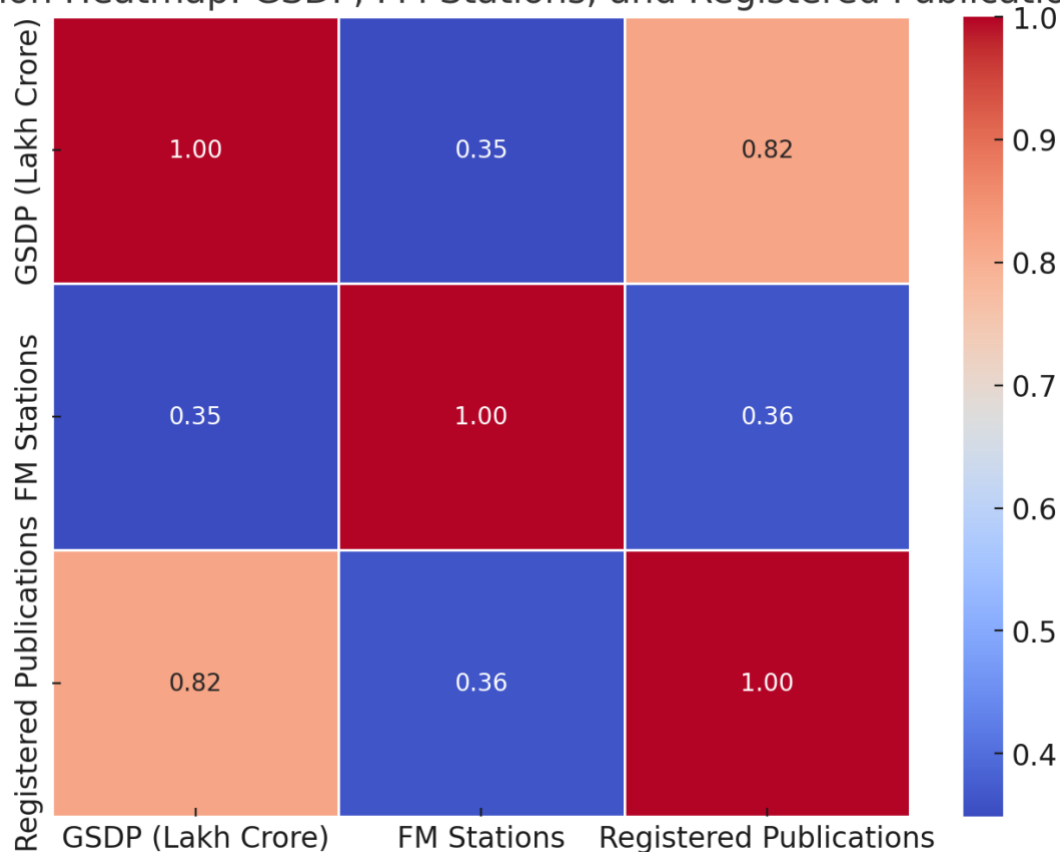


Figure 2

While existing literature has extensively examined the phenomenon of news deserts in Western contexts (Centre for Innovation & Sustainability in Local Media, 2019), there is limited understanding of how these dynamics play out in economically deprived regions like Central India. This research seeks to address this gap by exploring the paradox of media presence versus content in Chhattisgarh. Despite the presence of numerous media outlets, the lack of substantial coverage on critical issues like Naxalism and the disparity in reporting major incidents like rape cases reflect deeper systemic biases that prioritize economically prosperous regions over less developed ones.

As a media entrepreneur working in Chhattisgarh, I developed a platform aimed at giving tribal communities a voice, allowing them to share their stories and

concerns. This experience exposed me to the significant communication gap between these marginalized communities and the broader public discourse, exacerbated by the presence of Maoist insurgents who have exploited this isolation. This dissertation seeks to explore how local content producers—journalists and community storytellers—navigate the challenges of reporting in a news desert like Bastar. It specifically examines how they define their roles, perceive their successes, and contribute to bridging the gap between local realities and national narratives.

To explore this paradox, this study asks: How are boundary-spanning individuals (local content producers) in Chhattisgarh navigating the challenges of a news desert, and how do they perceive their role in bridging this gap? This question is crucial for understanding how local journalists and media producers can influence public discourse in regions where mainstream national media falls short. Sub-questions include: How do these journalists understand their tasks? How do they view their relationship with news production? What criteria do they use to determine that they have done a 'good job' in their reporting?

This research is vital not only for understanding the specific context of Chhattisgarh but also for shedding light on the broader implications for media policy and public discourse in underreported regions. By focusing on local journalists' strategies and perceptions, the study highlights the potential of local media to foster a more inclusive public sphere, even in economically deprived areas.

By uncovering the dynamics of media presence and content in Chhattisgarh, this dissertation not only contributes to academic discussions on news deserts and media economics but also suggests practical pathways for enhancing media coverage in underserved regions. The findings could inform policy interventions aimed at fostering more equitable and comprehensive media landscapes, ultimately contributing to a more informed and engaged public.

2. Literature Review

2.1 News Deserts

News deserts are regions characterized by limited access to local news coverage, a phenomenon that has significant implications for democratic participation and community engagement. According to Abernathy, news deserts are defined by the decline of local media outlets, resulting in reduced quality and quantity of local news (Abernathy, 2020). The characteristics of news deserts include economic and technological factors that contribute to their formation. Economically, the shift from traditional print media to digital platforms has disrupted the economic models of local newspapers, leading to closures and reduced coverage. Advertising revenue, once a mainstay for local media, has declined significantly as advertisers turn to online platforms (Abernathy, 2020).

Technologically, the rise of digital media has both enabled and hindered local journalism (Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism, 2023). While new platforms offer opportunities for community engagement, they also increase competition for traditional outlets, making it difficult for local media to sustain themselves. Studies by Gulyas, Jenkins, and Bergström highlight how these changes have affected local journalism, emphasizing the need for innovative strategies to sustain local news ecosystems in the digital age (Rodriguez-Amat, 2023).

The concentration of media ownership and the dominance of private companies in the media sector further exacerbate the challenges faced by local media. This concentration can lead to a homogenization of news content, where local issues are neglected in favour of national or international news. The result is a media landscape where local communities are underserved, and their voices are marginalized, further exacerbating the challenges of democratic participation and community cohesion.

In summary, news deserts are defined by their lack of local news coverage, driven by economic and technological factors. These factors include the decline of traditional media revenue, the rise of digital competition, and the concentration of media ownership, all of which contribute to the diminished availability and quality of local news.

2.2 Media Landscapes in Economically Deprived Regions

The relationship between economic conditions and media density is crucial in understanding the formation of news deserts, particularly in developing countries. Guerrero and Márquez-Ramírez's work on Latin American media systems highlights the concept of "captured liberal" systems, where media are dominated by privately-owned commercial entities. These systems are characterized by clientelism, patrimonialism, and collusion between media elites and powerful political and economic actors, resulting in low media autonomy and journalistic professionalism, distinguishing them from Western liberal systems (Guerrero & Márquez-Ramírez, 2014).

In regions like Chhattisgarh, India, economic conditions significantly influence media density. Supriya Sharma's content analysis demonstrates how the regional Hindi press often aligns with the government's perspective, neglecting marginalized communities' voices. This bias is partly due to reliance on government advertising and corporate interests, which can skew media coverage (Sharma, 2012).

The concentration of media ownership and the dominance of national outlets over local ones contribute to news deserts. This concentration leads to homogenized news content, where local issues are overshadowed by national or international news, leaving local communities underserved and their voices marginalized, exacerbating democratic participation and community cohesion challenges (Sharma, 2012).

In Chhattisgarh, the disparity in media coverage is evident, with the Maoist conflict in the south receiving more attention than the resource conflict in the north, despite its local significance. This disparity highlights the broader issue of underreporting in poor regions, where the lack of resources exacerbates local media challenges. Economic factors play a significant role in this disparity, as reliance on government advertising and corporate influence can lead to biased reporting that favours government perspectives. For example, regional Hindi newspapers like Dainik Bhaskar and Navabharat depend heavily on government advertising, resulting in the neglect of critical issues such as resource conflicts (Sharma, 2012).

2.3 Challenges Faced by Journalists in Conflict Zones

Journalists in conflict zones like Chhattisgarh face severe challenges, including restricted access to reliable information, violence, and threats. As Vasu, a Maoist leader, noted, verifying news is difficult due to limited communication, which authorities exploit to mislead both insurgents and the public (Choudhary, 2012). Additionally, language barriers further restrict media coverage, as there are few news broadcasts in local languages like Gondi (Choudhary, 2012). Journalists reporting on sensitive issues, such as human rights abuses, risk their safety, as seen with Kamlesh Painkra, who had to flee after covering Salwa Judum atrocities (Choudhary, 2012). These conditions underscore the importance of alternative media platforms to amplify underreported stories (Choudhary, 2012).

2.4 Violence and Intimidation

One of the most significant challenges is the risk of violence. In Chhattisgarh, journalists have been targeted by both the Maoist insurgents and the security forces. Supriya Sharma's study highlights the dangers faced by journalists in such environments: "The Maoists have often complained to activists that the media in Chhattisgarh is prejudiced against them... Correspondents, in turn, allege that police intimidation and lack of support from their editors and owners constrains them from representing the Maoist view" (Sharma, 2012, p. 48).

Echeverría and González's edited volume on Mexico provides comparative insights into the challenges faced by journalists operating in conflict zones in Latin America. The volume details how Mexican journalists, similar to those in Chhattisgarh, face violence from both state and non-state actors, such as drug cartels and corrupt officials, who aim to control narratives and suppress unfavourable reporting. Mexican journalists often employ strategies akin to those seen in Chhattisgarh, including reliance on official sources, self-censorship, and forming strategic alliances with local communities to gather information while ensuring their safety (Echeverría & González, 2022).

These strategies are not merely reactive but are shaped by the need to navigate complex power dynamics and maintain professional credibility in environments where media independence is constantly under threat. The ongoing violence and structural challenges in Mexico, as highlighted by various studies, underscore the precarious situation for journalists who must balance safety with their professional duties (Friedman, 2022). This situation is exacerbated by the blurred boundaries of journalism, where journalists must adopt safety measures to protect themselves and

continue their work despite limited resources and ongoing threats (Tandfonline, 2023).

2.5 Limited Access to Information

Journalists in conflict zones often face difficulties in accessing reliable sources of information. Sharma notes that "the whereabouts of Maoists are not known. They do not give out phone numbers on which they can be called" (Sharma, 2012, p. 49). This lack of access to primary sources forces journalists to rely heavily on official sources, which can lead to biased reporting. For instance, Shyam Betal of Navabharat explains, "It is a professional compulsion. Often the police are the only available source" (Sharma, 2012, p. 49).

2.6 Strategies Employed by Local Journalists

Despite these challenges, local journalists employ several strategies to navigate the complexities of reporting in conflict zones:

1. **Reliance on Official Sources:** Journalists often rely on official sources due to practical constraints. However, this can lead to biased reporting, as official sources may have vested interests in shaping the narrative. For example, "the primary identified sources of the newspapers are members of security forces and representatives of the government" (Sharma, 2012, p. 43).
2. **Use of Alternative Sources:** Some journalists attempt to contact Maoist sources directly. Aman Sethi of The Hindu notes, "If you report out of Chhattisgarh long enough, the Maoists will contact you" (Sharma, 2012, p. 49). This approach can provide a more balanced view but is not always feasible due to safety concerns and logistical challenges.
3. **Event-Oriented Reporting:** Journalists focus on reporting events rather than providing in-depth analysis. This event-orientation is driven by the need to keep

readers informed about daily disruptions. Rajeev Singh of Dainik Bhaskar explains, "It is our job to keep our readers informed of daily events... As long as there will be violent incidents, the coverage will be 'ghatnatmak' or episodic" (Sharma, 2012, p. 48).

4. Opinion Pieces and Analysis: To provide more depth, some newspapers rely on opinion pieces by experts. However, these are few and far between. Rajeev Singh acknowledges, "We fall back on opinion pieces by experts to give more depth to our coverage but accept such pieces are few and far between" (Sharma, 2012, p. 48).

2.7 Role of Local Content Producers in Addressing News Deserts

Local content producers are vital in filling the gaps created by news deserts, areas where mainstream media fails to provide comprehensive local coverage. Amado's work on the metaphors of journalism suggests that journalists are not just information providers but facilitators of conversation and community engagement. In news deserts, this role is crucial as local journalists help to bridge informational voids by fostering dialogue and offering platforms for diverse voices (Amado, 2021).

Amado argues that journalism should be seen as a form of community conversation, where local journalists act as mediators, enhancing civic engagement by covering topics like local governance and community events. This is particularly important in news deserts, where the lack of local news can lead to a disconnect from local decision-making processes. By engaging residents in local affairs, local content producers strengthen community bonds and democratic participation.

Moreover, local content producers support democratic participation by holding authorities accountable and highlighting issues that might be overlooked. Using Amado's metaphor of journalism as a "watchdog," local journalists in news deserts serve as essential checks on power, providing transparency and fostering informed decision-making among citizens.

Despite their importance, local content producers face challenges such as limited resources, safety risks, and competition with larger media outlets. Amado highlights the resilience required to continue their work in these environments, emphasizing their role as "fighters" who strive to ensure diverse and representative news coverage even in underreported regions. This persistence is crucial for maintaining a vibrant local media landscape, where the needs and voices of the community are adequately represented.

2.8 Methodology

2.8.1 Situating the Methodology within Existing Research

The choice of episodic interviews for this dissertation is grounded in established research methodologies within qualitative studies. Episodic interviewing, as developed by Uwe Flick, is particularly effective for capturing detailed, context-rich narratives from participants (Flick, 2011). This method is rooted in narrative psychology and distinguishes between episodic and semantic knowledge, offering a framework for understanding how individuals recall and narrate specific events and experiences. Flick (2011) emphasizes that episodic interviews are well-suited for studies that aim to explore subjective experiences, particularly in settings that require an understanding of personal and professional challenges, such as those faced by journalists in conflict zones like Bastar. The ability of episodic interviews to integrate both concrete situational contexts and more general knowledge frameworks makes them highly applicable for examining the complexities of journalistic work under threat.

2.8.2 Comparison with Other Methods

Although episodic interviews are the primary method chosen for this study, comparing them with other qualitative research methods helps to justify their selection. Semi-structured interviews, narrative interviews, and the critical incident technique each offer unique strengths in qualitative research. Semi-structured

interviews provide flexibility and depth but may not elicit the same focused narratives about specific events as episodic interviews. The critical incident technique, while effective for identifying significant events, tends to focus on predefined situations rather than allowing participants to select events of personal relevance, which can limit the depth of understanding about broader experiences (Flanagan, 1954; Flick, 2011). Narrative interviews encourage participants to recount their life stories in a free-flowing manner, yielding rich data, but may lack the structure needed to focus on specific episodes of interest (Schütze, 1977). In contrast, episodic interviews strike a balance by inviting participants to recount specific events while also allowing for broader reflections, making them ideal for capturing the complexities of journalistic work in conflict zones (Flick, 2011).

2.8.3 Discussing Methodological Trends in the Field

The choice of episodic interviews aligns with broader methodological trends in journalism and media studies, particularly those focusing on conflict zones and underreported regions. Recent studies increasingly emphasize the need for methods that capture the nuanced experiences of journalists who work under hazardous conditions, highlighting the importance of understanding both the personal and professional impacts of their work. Episodic interviews are well-regarded in this context for their ability to elicit rich, detailed narratives that provide insights into the challenges faced by journalists and the strategies they employ to navigate complex environments (Bauer, 1996; Flick, 2011). This method's flexibility in accommodating both narrative and argumentative responses makes it particularly valuable in fields like media studies, where understanding the interplay between personal experience and broader socio-political contexts is crucial.

By grounding the use of episodic interviews in the existing literature and comparing them with other qualitative methods, this study demonstrates a careful and informed methodological choice. This approach ensures that the data collected will be well-suited to addressing the research questions, offering a comprehensive understanding of the experiences of journalists in Bastar and contributing to broader discussions about the role of local content producers in news deserts.

Research Questions

How do these boundary-spanning people deal with the news desert and see their role in bridging that desert and greening that desert?

- 1. *How do they understand their task?***
- 2. *How do they understand the relation with news in general?***
- 3. *How do they know they have done a good job?***

3. Methodology:

This research utilizes a qualitative approach, specifically episodic interviews, to explore the experiences and perceptions of journalists working in news deserts in Bastar, Central India. Qualitative methods are ideal for this study as they provide an in-depth understanding of the journalists' lived experiences, highlighting the complexities of their roles, challenges, and strategies in a region that is often underreported. Episodic interviews are particularly suitable because they focus on specific events and stories that illustrate the realities of reporting in Bastar. This method allows journalists to share detailed accounts of particular episodes, revealing the dynamics of working in a challenging media landscape and their coping mechanisms and ethical considerations. By capturing concrete situations, episodic interviews provide rich, nuanced insights into the professional experiences of local content producers, offering a flexible framework that enhances the authenticity and depth of the data collected, making it highly relevant for understanding the complexities of working in a news desert.

3.1 Comparative Analysis and Methodology

Episodic interviewing is suitable for capturing the narratives of local content producers in Bastar because it focuses on specific episodes or events that provide detailed insights into their professional experiences and challenges. This method allows journalists to recount concrete situations, highlighting their reporting strategies, ethical dilemmas, and interactions with local and national media. It also offers a flexible framework, enabling interviewees to select relevant episodes, which enhances the depth and authenticity of the data, making it highly effective for understanding the complexities of working in a news desert.

This study uses a comparative analysis to examine how factors such as gender, experience, organizational affiliation, and regional context shape journalists'

experiences in Bastar. By comparing responses from male (e.g., P1 from Raipur) and female journalists (e.g., P6 from Jagdalpur), the study explores potential gender-based disparities in access to sources, reporting focus, and safety concerns in a conflict zone.

Examining differences between journalists who started their careers before and after the Salwa Judum movement (e.g., P1 and P3) reveals how historical and political contexts affect journalistic freedom and safety. During the Salwa Judum, journalists faced significant threats and pressure to conform to state narratives, impacting their ability to report independently. Understanding these effects is crucial for assessing how significant events reshape media practices and influence journalists' strategies.

Comparing journalists with varying levels of experience, from veterans like P1 with 35 years in the field to newer journalists like P8 with 5 years, helps identify which skills and strategies are most effective in navigating the challenges of a news desert. The study also contrasts journalists working with large media organizations (e.g., P1 from BBC/CGNet Swara) versus independent outlets (e.g., P8) to understand how resources and editorial policies influence journalistic autonomy and storytelling.

Lastly, the study examines the use of digital platforms, such as YouTube journalism (e.g., P3 and P8), to understand how digital media offers different levels of editorial freedom and engagement compared to traditional media. This analysis is important for understanding the evolving dynamics of journalism in underreported regions and the potential for digital platforms to address gaps left by traditional outlets.

These comparative elements are aligned with the research questions and aim to provide a nuanced understanding of journalists' diverse experiences in Bastar, helping to identify patterns and differences that influence their role in bridging information gaps in news deserts.

3.2 Participant selection

The study involved 14 journalists from Bastar, selected to reflect a diverse range of experiences, backgrounds, and perspectives essential to understanding journalism in a news desert. The participants included male and female journalists, ages 25 to 62, with experience levels ranging from 5 to 35 years. They were chosen based on criteria such as ethnic background (tribal and non-tribal), organizational affiliation (working with local independent outlets or large media houses), and geographical coverage area within Bastar. This diverse representation is crucial for capturing the varied challenges and strategies journalists employ, as well as understanding the impact of factors such as gender, ethnicity, and regional dynamics on their work. By including a broad spectrum of journalists, the study aims to provide a nuanced understanding of how these differences shape their roles and approaches in reporting within an underreported region.

3.3 Recruitment Process

For the recruitment process, I employed two primary strategies. The first, which I called the "sniper gun strategy," involved a targeted approach where I reached out to specific journalists whose work I had been following for years, such as P2, P3, and P14. I crafted personalized messages highlighting how their specific contributions could enrich my dissertation, sent via WhatsApp alongside a standard recruitment message. This personalized approach was necessary due to their busy schedules and the need to convey the relevance of their participation to my research. The second strategy, a "snowball sampling" method, involved asking participants like P1 to refer other journalists meeting my criteria. This approach proved effective in reaching out to those I did not have prior contact with, and I sent standardized invitations to them. Throughout this process, I faced challenges such as low response rates and the need to reschedule interviews due to unexpected events, which required flexibility and persistence.

3.4 Data Collection Methods

Data was collected through episodic interviews conducted primarily on Zoom, with the Zoom recorder used to capture audio and video. Given the participants' location in India and the time difference with London, interviews were often scheduled for early morning IST, presenting logistical challenges for finding quiet spaces in London for uninterrupted conversations. I often had to use cafes that opened early, selecting quiet corners to ensure privacy and minimize background noise. Contacting participants via phone presented another challenge; due to security concerns, many journalists were hesitant to answer calls from international numbers. Therefore, I primarily used WhatsApp for both voice calls and text communication to arrange interviews. Despite these challenges, I was able to interview 15 of the 29 journalists initially contacted. Additionally, some interviews were disrupted by unforeseen events, such as the arrest of a journalist, which led to cancellations and required rescheduling. These experiences highlight the unpredictable nature of conducting research in conflict zones and the need for adaptable methods and clear communication strategies.

3.5 Positionality and Researcher Reflexivity

As a researcher with previous professional connections to some participants, such as P1, and having followed the work of others like P2 and P3, my positionality could introduce biases into the research process. Being familiar with the local journalistic landscape allowed me to gain trust quickly, but it also posed a risk of bias in interpreting responses, potentially influencing my analysis. To mitigate this, I maintained a reflexive journal to document my thoughts and biases throughout the research process and engaged in regular discussions with colleagues to reflect on my position and its impact on the data collected. This practice helped ensure a more objective and balanced approach to data interpretation.

3.6 Transcription and Data Management

Following the interviews, I transcribed all recordings using YouTube's automatic transcription tool, uploading the Zoom files as private videos. This tool provided a strong foundation, but I manually reviewed each transcript to achieve verbatim accuracy and ensure the representation of non-verbal cues, such as pauses and intonations, which are crucial for understanding the context and depth of the participants' responses (Oliver, 2005). This meticulous transcription process aligns with best practices in qualitative research, enhancing the trustworthiness of the data by capturing nuances like elisions, mispronunciations, and background noises (McLellan et al., 2003). These details help to gain a deeper understanding of the participants' attitudes, values, beliefs, and experiences, contributing to a richer, more comprehensive analysis (Nowell, 2017).

3.7 Ethical Considerations

Before data collection, the research was reviewed and approved by the LSE Department of Psychological and Behavioural Science Ethics Committee, confirming it as low risk. This study involved significant ethical considerations due to the sensitive nature of the topics discussed and the challenging environments in which the journalists operate. Informed consent was obtained from all participants, with assurances about their right to withdraw at any time and the confidentiality measures in place to protect their identities. Given the use of personal networks for recruitment, there was a risk that participants might feel a stronger connection to the researcher, potentially influencing their willingness to share personal insights. To mitigate this, a standard ethical protocol was followed, and participants were reminded of their right to confidentiality and anonymity. Additionally, communication methods were adapted to respect participants' privacy and safety concerns, particularly in a conflict zone. By maintaining a reflective journal and adhering to rigorous ethical standards, the researcher aimed to minimize bias and ensure the integrity of the data collection process.

3.8 Data Analysis

3.8.1 Thematic Analysis

Thematic analysis will be employed to systematically identify and analyse patterns within the qualitative data collected from the interviews with journalists. This approach involves an initial open coding phase, where each transcript will be read closely to identify recurring themes and categories that are significant to the participants' experiences and perspectives. NVivo software will be used to facilitate the coding process, allowing for the organization and categorization of large volumes of text. Following the initial coding, axial coding will be conducted to refine and focus the codes into broader themes that capture the essence of journalists' experiences in a news desert. Thematic analysis is particularly suited to this study because it enables the exploration of complex and context-specific issues, helping to uncover how journalists perceive their roles, challenges, and strategies in their unique professional environments.

3.8.2 Episodic Analysis

Episodic analysis will be utilized to explore specific events or episodes recounted by journalists, providing a rich, detailed understanding of their lived experiences. This method focuses on narratives that describe concrete situations, allowing participants to recall significant moments that shaped their professional practices. The episodic interview technique, as outlined by Flick (2011), will guide the analysis by examining both the specific content of these episodes and the broader semantic knowledge they reveal. This approach is particularly valuable for capturing the nuances of working in conflict zones like Bastar, where individual experiences of events such as censorship, violence, or political pressure significantly impact journalistic practices. By analysing these episodes, the study aims to understand not just what happened, but how journalists make sense of these events and the coping strategies they employ, thereby providing a deeper insight into the realities of reporting in a news desert.

4. Findings

4.1 Introduction to Findings

The purpose of this section is to present the key findings from the analysis of episodic interviews conducted with local content producers in Central India. The findings are organized around three global themes that emerged from the thematic and episodic analysis: Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert, Challenges in Bridging the News Desert, and Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas. Each theme provides insight into how these individuals perceive their roles and responsibilities, navigate the challenges of operating in a news desert, and deal with the ethical and editorial constraints that impact their work.

These global themes are intrinsically connected to the research question: "How are these boundary-spanning individuals dealing with the news desert, and how do they see their role in bridging and greening that desert?" The themes help to unpack the ways in which local content producers perceive their task of bridging the information gap, their strategies for navigating logistical and financial barriers, and their approaches to maintaining journalistic integrity amidst external pressures. By exploring these themes, the findings illuminate the complexities of producing news in underreported regions and the multifaceted roles that these journalists play in addressing the challenges posed by news deserts.

The thematic map presented below provides a visual representation of the global themes and their connections to the research question and sub-questions. It serves as a roadmap for the detailed discussion that follows, highlighting how each theme and its sub-themes contribute to a deeper understanding of the role and perceptions of local content producers in Central India.

Each theme is further elaborated with sub-themes that delve into specific aspects of their experiences, supported by direct quotations from the interviews to provide a nuanced perspective on the dynamics at play in these regions. The subsequent

sections will provide a comprehensive analysis of each global theme, illustrating the diverse ways in which local content producers navigate, adapt, and respond to the challenges and responsibilities of their roles in a news desert.

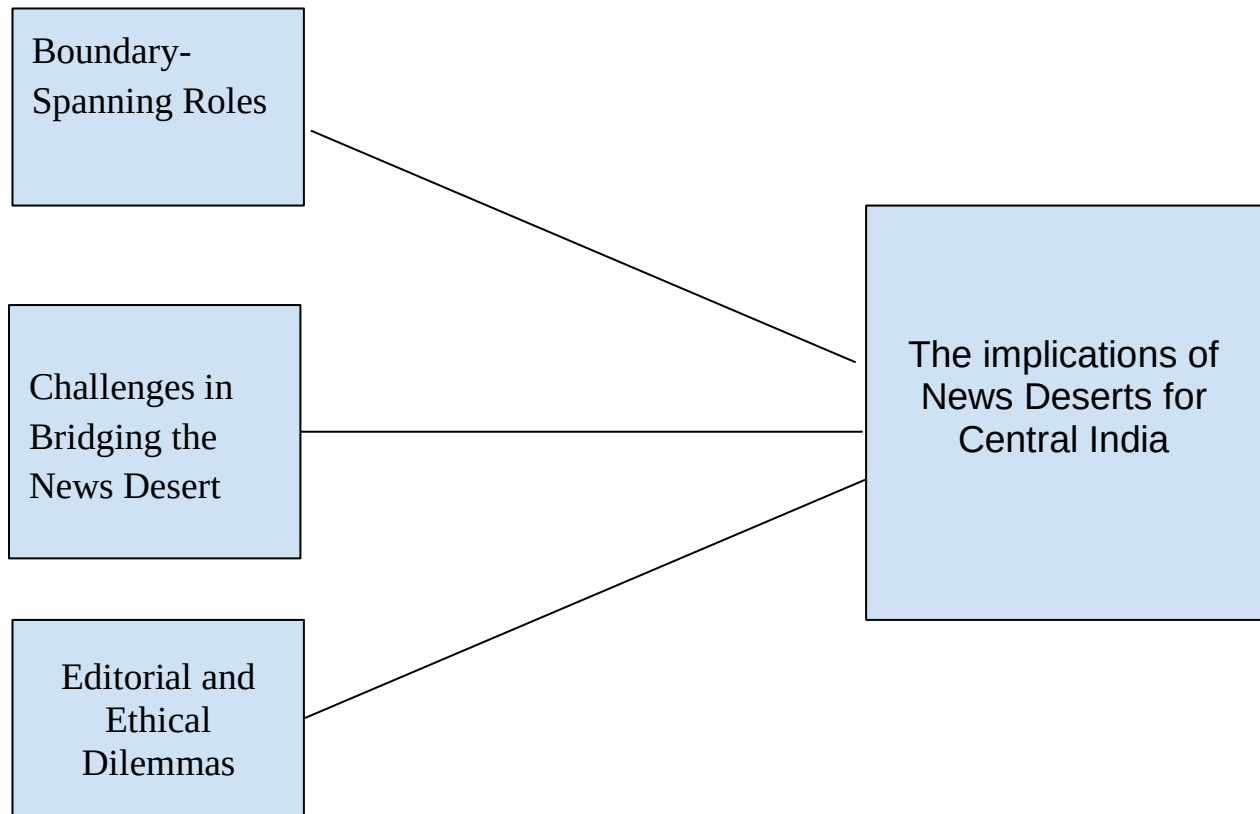


FIGURE-1

4.2 Overview of Global Themes

The thematic analysis of interviews with local content producers in Central India revealed three key global themes: Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert, Challenges in Bridging the News Desert, and Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas.

These themes are integral to understanding the diverse roles and perceptions of journalists operating in areas with limited access to reliable news sources, often referred to as "news deserts."

Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert explores how journalists view their roles not just as a profession, but as a civic duty to bridge information gaps in underserved areas. This theme directly addresses the research question by illustrating how local content producers aim to "bridge and green the desert," acting as essential conduits of information between marginalized communities and the broader public. For instance, one journalist stated, "To me, it feels like a duty... I have the ability to be the voice of millions whose voices are not heard," emphasizing the perceived responsibility to provide a platform for unheard voices.

Challenges in Bridging the News Desert focuses on the logistical, financial, and operational barriers these journalists face, which directly impacts their ability to perform their roles effectively. This theme responds to the sub-questions by detailing how these challenges shape journalists' understanding of their tasks and their relationship with news production. For example, the lack of financial support and reliance on government advertising restricts editorial freedom, making it difficult to report unbiased news. A participant noted, "There journalists are not paid adequately... Many institutions do not pay them at all," highlighting the economic difficulties of sustaining independent journalism in these regions.

Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas examine the conflicts and ethical challenges faced by journalists in politically sensitive contexts. This theme provides insight into how local content producers navigate the fine line between truthful reporting and maintaining community safety. It answers the sub-question about what constitutes a "good job" by showcasing the ethical considerations journalists must weigh. One journalist recounted, "Sometimes we have to remain silent if the report could harm the community or incite violence," demonstrating the delicate balance between transparency and responsibility.

The thematic map below visually represents these global themes and their sub-themes, illustrating the complex interrelationships between them and how they collectively contribute to answering the research question. This visual aids in

understanding the interconnected nature of the findings and sets the stage for a more in-depth exploration in the following sections.

Additionally, these themes align with existing literature on journalism in marginalized communities, expanding on theories of media representation, journalistic ethics, and the economics of news production. Notably, this study contributes new insights into the unique challenges faced by journalists in news deserts, offering a more nuanced understanding of their roles and responsibilities.

4.3 Global Theme 1: Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert

The global theme of "Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert" investigates how local content producers in Central India perceive and navigate their roles amid the constraints of a news desert—regions lacking sufficient news coverage from mainstream media outlets. This theme is critical for understanding how these journalists act as connectors or "boundary-spanners," facilitating communication and understanding between isolated, underrepresented communities and the broader national discourse. In doing so, they take on dual roles: "bridging" the news desert by highlighting stories overlooked by larger media and "greening" it by fostering a more diverse and inclusive media landscape.

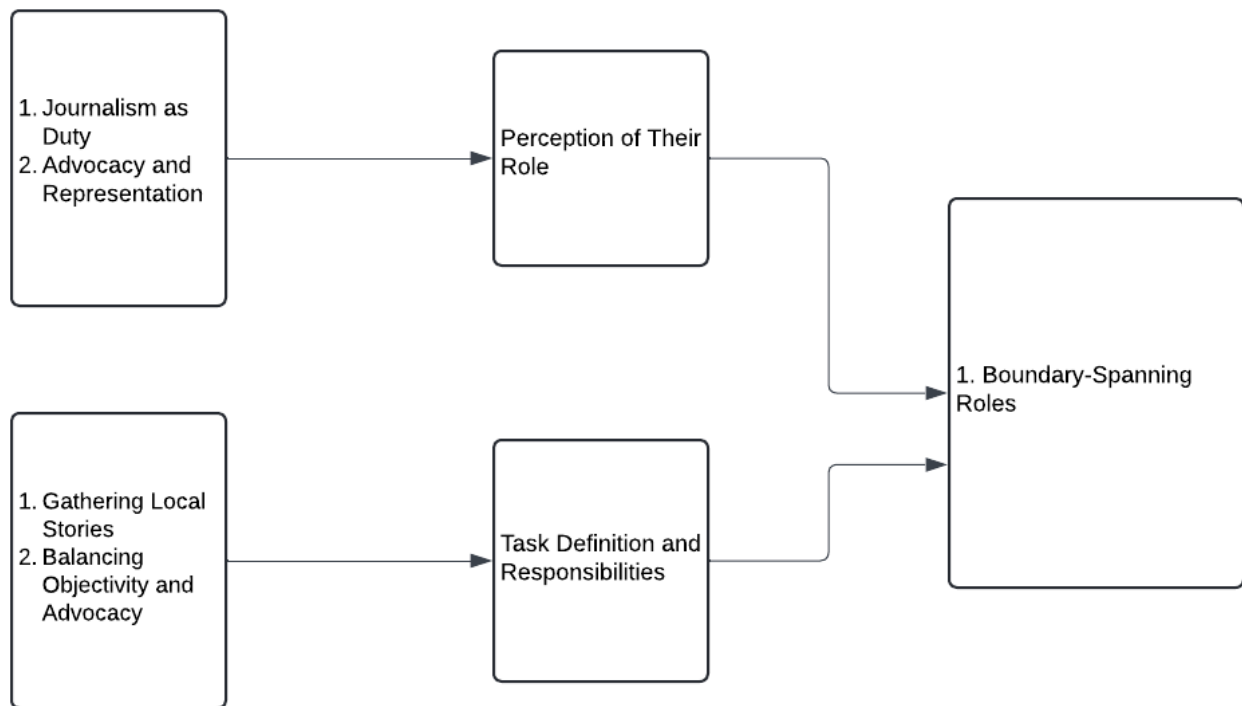


Figure 2

This theme directly addresses the research question by exploring how local content producers view their responsibilities not just as reporters, but as advocates and community members who the sole voices are often raising awareness about local issues. For example, many journalists see their work as a civic duty, striving to represent communities that have been marginalized in national narratives. However, this role is not without challenges; producers often face threats and logistical hurdles, reflecting the difficult terrain—both literal and figurative—they must navigate to fulfil their duties. Despite these obstacles, their efforts contribute significantly to bridging informational gaps and promoting more equitable media representation, thereby enhancing our understanding of the critical function of local journalism in underrepresented regions.

4.3.1 Organizing Theme: Perception of Their Role

The organizing theme "Perception of Their Role" highlights how local content producers in Central India view their responsibilities as transcending traditional journalism. For many, journalism is a personal calling and civic duty, not just a job. P1 shared, "Journalism is not just about reporting facts; it's about giving a voice to those who have been silenced," while P4 noted, "I see my work as a bridge between the unheard stories of my community and the broader world." These perceptions directly address the research question, illustrating how these journalists perceive their roles in bridging the news desert. They see themselves as essential for representing their communities and as defenders of democracy and social justice, working to bring light to issues affecting the marginalized. This relates to the sub-question about how they understand their tasks—viewing their work as a mission to give voice to the voiceless and hold power accountable.

Moreover, "Advocacy and Representation" captures the belief among these journalists that their role extends beyond neutral reporting to actively advocating for underserved communities. P7 expressed, "We are constantly trying to address the needs of the tribals... if there is any injustice, we write about it." This proactive stance illustrates how they view themselves as a bridge between these communities and broader society, using their platform to highlight otherwise unaddressed issues. This connects with the sub-question about how they understand their relation to news—seeing their work as activism aimed at correcting imbalances in coverage and advocating for those lacking representation in national media. P9 added, "For us, success isn't just about breaking a story; it's about making sure the story leads to change," emphasizing how they measure success by the impact of their stories on their communities, aligning with the sub-question about how they know they've done a good job.

4.3.2 Organizing Theme: Task Definition and Responsibilities

The organizing theme "Task Definition and Responsibilities" explores how journalists in Central India perceive their roles and the specific duties they undertake in the context of a news desert. This theme provides insight into the daily practices and ethical considerations that shape their work.

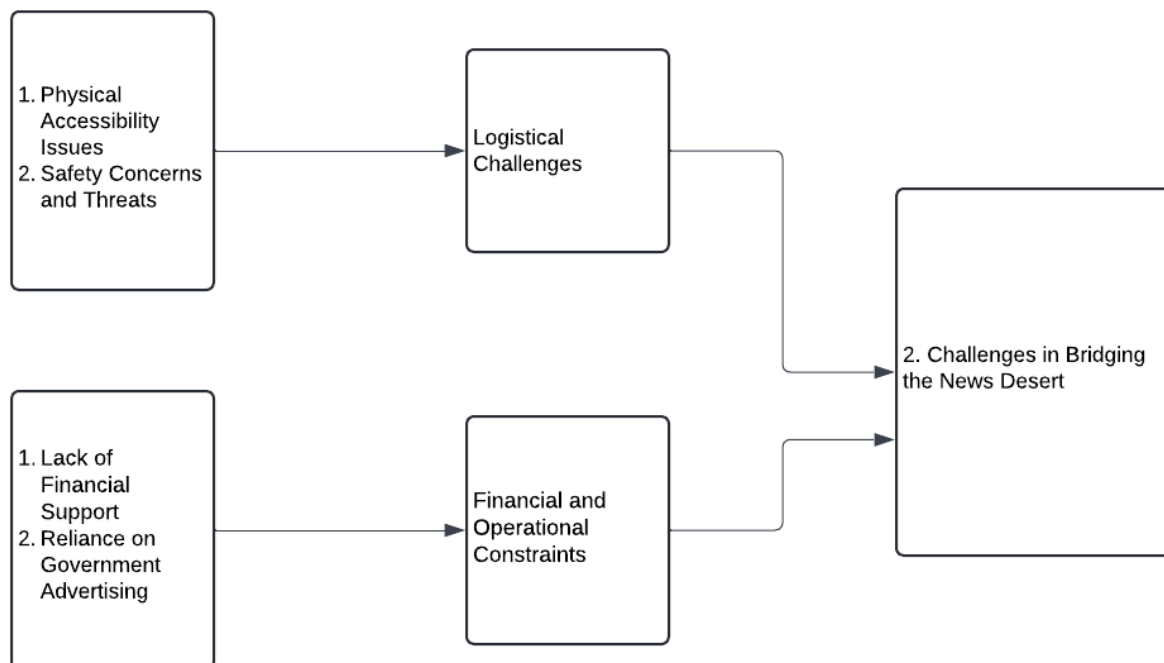
Journalists see their tasks as going beyond mere reporting; they view themselves as guardians of truth in an environment where stories are often underreported or misrepresented by national media. They take on the responsibility of uncovering and disseminating local stories that are frequently overlooked. P3 noted, "We go into the jungle, walk for miles, and bring out stories that are not otherwise told." This task of gathering local stories involves substantial effort, highlighting the challenges they face in ensuring their communities are accurately portrayed.

Moreover, these journalists balance their role as objective reporters with the need to advocate for their communities. They often navigate situations where they must choose between reporting facts and protecting their communities from potential harm. P5 reflected, "We don't work with prejudice. If something is wrong, we collect evidence and report it, but if it's good for society, we take a positive approach." This underscores the dual nature of their responsibilities—maintaining journalistic integrity while safeguarding community interests.

This theme directly addresses the research question by illustrating how journalists perceive their role in bridging the news desert. They define their tasks in terms of both traditional journalistic duties and their commitment to ensuring local issues are represented in the broader media landscape. It also connects to the sub-question about understanding their tasks, as these journalists navigate the tension between objectivity and advocacy, demonstrating the complexity of their roles in a region with limited media representation.

4.4 Global Theme 2: Challenges in Bridging the News Desert

The global theme "Challenges in Bridging the News Desert" captures the numerous obstacles that local content producers in Central India face while striving to fill the gaps left by mainstream media. This theme is closely tied to the research question, which investigates how these journalists perceive their roles in addressing the deficiencies of a news desert and how they view their contributions to creating a more informed society. The challenges they encounter are not only logistical but also financial, editorial, and ethical, each presenting a unique barrier to their work.



Local journalists often work under extremely difficult conditions, markedly different from those in more urbanized areas. Participant P4 highlighted the logistical hurdles, stating, "Sometimes we have to walk 50 kilometres to reach a village and see the reality," illustrating the physical challenges of accessing remote areas. Safety concerns further complicate their efforts. As Participant P7 expressed, "I have received several threats from both the police and the Naxalites," pointing to the danger inherent in their reporting environment.

Financial constraints are another significant challenge, with many journalists operating without adequate funding. Participant P9 noted, "Rural journalists are often not paid at all, and this forces some to rely on other means to sustain themselves," revealing the precarious financial situations many journalists find themselves in. Additionally, reliance on government advertising creates editorial pressure, limiting their ability to report freely. As Participant P3 stated, "If you write against them, they might cut your advertisements... it's a way to control us," emphasizing the editorial constraints they navigate.

These challenges are integral to understanding the broader question of how local content producers see their role in bridging the news desert. They illuminate the practical limitations and ethical dilemmas that shape their ability to function as both reporters and advocates for their communities. Despite these obstacles, the dedication and resilience of these journalists reflect a deep commitment to their work and their communities, demonstrating their role as crucial actors in a complex media landscape.

4.4.1 Organizing Theme 2.1: Logistical Challenges

The organizing theme "Logistical Challenges" under the global theme "Challenges in Bridging the News Desert" highlights the physical and safety obstacles local content producers face while reporting in remote and underdeveloped regions of Central India. These challenges are deeply tied to the socio-political complexities of the areas they cover.

Journalists encounter significant difficulties accessing remote locations due to inadequate infrastructure like roads and transportation. P7 stated, "Reaching some villages means walking for hours, sometimes through dense forests or up steep hills, just to get to the heart of the story." This illustrates the physical endurance required to bring underreported local stories to light, a task made more challenging by natural barriers isolating these communities. P2 described navigating rugged terrain to reach a village: "I decided to go there even though no vehicles could reach, not even bikes. We made a path by pushing the bikes through." These examples underscore the logistical hurdles significantly impacting timely and

accurate reporting from underrepresented regions, reinforcing the "news desert" phenomenon.

Safety concerns further exacerbate these difficulties. Reporting in conflict zones, particularly areas controlled by Naxalite groups or under heavy police surveillance, poses constant threats to journalists. P4 shared, "We've had incidents where our paths were booby-trapped or where we were caught in the crossfire between police and Naxals. The fear is always there." P4 also explained, "I have received several threats from the Naxal organization. They are not happy with my reporting on both the police and the Naxalites, and they have issued warnings to stop covering these stories." This illustrates the precarious position journalists find themselves in, caught between conflicting forces. P2 highlighted the psychological toll, noting, "There is always a fear of either being ambushed or stepping on a landmine while going into remote villages for ground reporting. It's a death situation every moment here." Despite these threats, journalists continue their work, driven by a commitment to uncovering truth and advocating for their communities.

These challenges directly relate to the research question by showcasing how boundary-spanning journalists deal with the news desert, risking their lives to bridge information gaps. It connects to the sub-questions about understanding their tasks and relation to news, as they navigate complex realities to fulfil their roles as information providers, despite logistical and safety hurdles.

4.4.2 Organizing Theme: Financial and Operational Constraints

The organizing theme "Financial and Operational Constraints" under the global theme "Challenges in Bridging the News Desert" highlights the significant financial and operational limitations local journalists face in Central India. These constraints impact their ability to report effectively and influence the quality and depth of journalism produced in regions characterized as news deserts.

Local journalists often operate with minimal financial support, leading to a scarcity of resources necessary for comprehensive reporting. P3 noted, "Rural journalists are not paid adequately... Many institutions do not pay them at all, which forces us to look for other means to sustain ourselves." This financial instability compels

journalists to engage in alternative income-generating activities, detracting from their ability to focus fully on their journalistic duties.

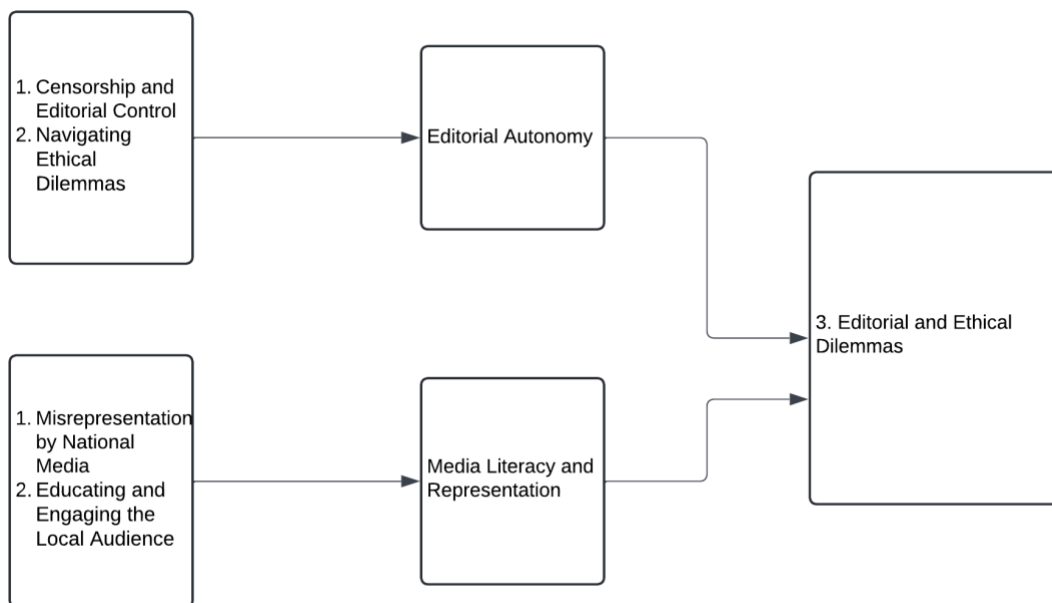
Moreover, the dependence on government advertisements poses a critical operational challenge. Local media outlets often rely on government ads as their primary revenue source, creating a conflict of interest and compromising editorial independence. P1 emphasized, "The biggest challenge is that newspapers run on advertisements, and the government gives them. If you write against them, they will not like you, and you risk losing your primary revenue source." This financial reliance forces many local journalists to practice self-censorship to avoid backlash or loss of funding. P4 added, "If we criticize the government too much, they pull back their advertisements, and without that income, it's tough to keep the paper running."

Additionally, high operational costs associated with reporting in remote areas exacerbate these challenges. P7 described the situation: "We often have to pay for our travel and sometimes stay overnight in dangerous areas without any support from our news organizations." Such financial and operational constraints limit journalists' ability to cover stories comprehensively and accurately, leading to gaps in the representation of local issues and narratives.

These challenges directly relate to the research question by illustrating how boundary-spanning journalists deal with the news desert, navigating financial insecurity and operational barriers while striving to maintain journalistic integrity and commitment to community advocacy. The sub-questions about understanding their tasks and relation to news are addressed as journalists balance the need for financial survival with their role as watchdogs, often compromising editorial independence to secure necessary funding. The lack of resources and reliance on government advertising underscore the precarious nature of local journalism in Central India's news deserts, affecting the diversity and depth of news available to the public.

4.5 Global Theme 3: Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas

The global theme of "Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas" captures the complex challenges faced by local journalists in Central India as they navigate ethical conflicts and editorial constraints. This theme is crucial to the research question because it reveals how journalists understand their roles in bridging the news desert while facing pressures that test their commitment to truth and independence. Many journalists must balance the responsibility of reporting honestly with the realities of external influences such as political interference, economic dependency, and threats to personal safety.



Participants frequently discussed the ethical tensions they face in their work. For example, P3 shared, "There are stories that we want to publish, but we know the repercussions could be severe — for us and for our families." This highlights the difficult choices journalists must make to protect their own safety while still trying to inform the public. P5 emphasized the pressure from political entities, stating, "Sometimes, we receive direct or indirect pressure not to cover certain topics. It's a

subtle form of censorship, but it's very effective." These quotes illustrate the dilemmas that local journalists face in maintaining their editorial independence. By examining these ethical and editorial challenges, this theme provides a deeper understanding of how journalists in underrepresented regions negotiate their roles and responsibilities amidst a landscape of censorship, economic constraints, and political influence.

4.5.1 Organizing Theme: Editorial Autonomy

The organizing theme "Editorial Autonomy" explores the degree of independence journalists in Central India experience in their work, highlighting the constraints and pressures shaping the journalistic landscape in these underreported regions.

Journalists often face significant limitations on their editorial freedom from both internal and external sources. P2 noted, "The stories we publish are often dictated by those who fund us. It's not about what's important to the community but about what won't upset the powers that be." The lack of financial independence further exacerbates these constraints, as P7 stated, "Without financial backing, we are at the mercy of our sponsors, many of whom have their own agendas."

Additionally, journalists face direct censorship from superiors, who may alter or reject stories seen as too controversial. P5 shared, "I had a story on corruption ready to go, but the editor told me to 'tone it down' because we didn't want to 'ruffle any feathers.' Eventually, the story was buried completely."

Moreover, journalists find themselves at a crossroads between ethical reporting and the potential harm their stories could cause. P3 shared, "I had evidence of police misconduct, but the community asked me not to publish the story because it might lead to more violence. I was torn between my duty to inform the public and my responsibility not to cause harm."

In sum, the theme of editorial autonomy reveals the complexities of journalistic practice in Central India, where financial dependencies, political pressures, editorial censorship, and ethical dilemmas intersect, often forcing journalists to choose between their professional integrity and the viability of their operations.

4.5.2 Organizing Theme: Media Literacy and Representation

The organizing theme "Media Literacy and Representation" explores how journalists in Central India perceive their role as educators and advocates for accurate representation in media, in addition to their primary role as reporters. This theme highlights the dual responsibility that local journalists feel—to report news truthfully and to educate their communities about media consumption and representation.

Journalists in news deserts like Central India often encounter significant misrepresentation of their communities in national and international media. P8 shared, "The national media only shows a fraction of what's happening here. They focus on violence and conflict, but there's so much more to our stories that goes untold." In response, many local journalists take on the additional role of media educators. P5 explained, "We have to teach people here how to interpret the news they consume. Many are not aware of the biases and agendas that can shape a story."

Furthermore, journalists strive to bridge the gap between their local reality and the broader narratives that dominate mainstream media. P2 noted, "Our job is not just to report; it's to represent our people accurately and to challenge the dominant narratives that often marginalize us." P3 expressed a common sentiment: "Whenever the national media covers our area, they only talk about Naxalism or poverty. They never show the daily lives of people here, their culture, or their achievements."

To address this, journalists take proactive steps to improve media literacy among their communities. P6 emphasized the importance of transparency and education, stating, "We regularly conduct workshops and community meetings to explain how news is gathered and why it matters. We teach people to question what they see and hear, especially on social media."

By prioritizing media literacy and striving for accurate representation, journalists in Central India play a critical role in fostering a more informed public discourse.

They serve not only as reporters but also as guardians of their communities' stories, ensuring that these narratives are told with authenticity and respect.

4.6 Summary of Findings

The thematic analysis reveals critical insights into the roles, challenges, and ethical dilemmas faced by local content producers in Central India's news deserts. The findings are organized around three global themes: "Boundary-Spanning Roles in a News Desert," "Challenges in Bridging the News Desert," and "Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas."

The first theme highlights how journalists see themselves as civic duty bearers and advocates for their communities, connecting to the literature on the civic functions of journalism but extending it by showing how these journalists act as social workers in conflict zones. The second theme identifies logistical and financial constraints impacting local journalism, supporting previous research about infrastructural challenges but also highlighting unique financial dependencies that can threaten editorial independence. The third theme reveals that journalists often face censorship and ethical conflicts, offering new insights into the strategies they employ to navigate their ethical landscapes.

These findings contribute to a more comprehensive view of the intersection between journalism, advocacy, and community engagement in news deserts. By highlighting both the resilience of local journalists and the systemic barriers they face, this study provides a fresh perspective on the complexities of journalism in conflict-affected regions, directly addressing the research question and sub-questions about how boundary-spanning journalists deal with news deserts, understand their tasks, and relate to news in general.

5. Discussion:

The purpose of this study was to explore the implications of news deserts in Central India by interviewing local content producers to understand their roles and perceptions in bridging and greening these deserts. The main research question focused on how these boundary-spanning journalists navigate the challenges of reporting in underserved areas and their strategies for ensuring comprehensive news coverage. The study also sought to address sub-questions related to how these journalists define their tasks, perceive their relationship with the broader news landscape, and evaluate their success in reporting.

In this discussion, we will interpret the findings in relation to these research questions, providing a detailed analysis of the global themes that emerged from the data. We will compare the results with existing literature, highlight the theoretical implications, and discuss the limitations of the study. Furthermore, recommendations for future research and key learnings from this investigation will be presented to provide a comprehensive understanding of the study's contributions to the field.

5.1 Compare and Contrast with Existing Literature

The findings of this study on the role of local content producers in addressing news deserts in Central India reveal both alignment with and divergence from existing literature on news deserts, media landscapes in poor regions, and the challenges faced by journalists in conflict zones.

5.1.1 Alignment with Existing Literature

Firstly, the study's findings are consistent with the literature on news deserts, which highlights the diminishing access to local news because of economic and technological changes (Abernathy, 2020). This study supports the notion that economic constraints, such as limited financial resources and reliance on government advertising, significantly impact local journalism. Journalists in

Central India echoed concerns about financial instability, similar to those discussed by Abernathy, noting that the shift from print to digital media, combined with a concentration of media ownership, exacerbates these challenges. Additionally, the study confirms Gulyas, Jenkins, and Bergström's (2023) findings that digital platforms, while offering opportunities, also intensify competition, making it harder for local journalists to sustain operations.

The findings also align with Supriya Sharma's (2012) observations on the challenges faced by journalists in conflict zones, such as violence, intimidation, and limited access to reliable information. Journalists in Central India reported threats from both Maoist insurgents and state actors, corroborating Sharma's assertions about the precarious nature of reporting in such environments. These parallels highlight the global nature of the risks faced by journalists in conflict zones and reinforce the necessity of strategies like reliance on official sources and event-oriented reporting, as discussed by Sharma.

5.1.2 New Insights and Divergences from Existing Literature

Despite these alignments, the study also presents new insights that challenge or expand upon existing literature. One significant divergence is the proactive role that local journalists in Central India see themselves playing in bridging the information gap created by news deserts. Unlike the depiction of journalists in poor regions as largely passive recipients of economic and structural constraints (Guerrero & Márquez-Ramírez, 2014), the study finds that these journalists actively engage in advocacy and community representation. This finding extends Amado's (2021) metaphor of journalists as "fighters" and "facilitators of conversation," emphasizing their resilience and commitment to addressing local needs despite significant challenges.

Moreover, the study introduces the concept of journalists as educators and mediators in their communities, a role not extensively covered in the existing literature. While Tuchman's (1978) concept of the "news net" describes the structural limitations of news gathering, this study reveals that local journalists often go beyond these constraints by engaging in efforts to improve media literacy and actively involving the community in the news production process. This educational role highlights a new dimension of journalism in news deserts,

suggesting a more dynamic interaction between journalists and their audiences than previously documented.

5.1.3 Challenges to Existing Theories

The study also challenges the prevailing narrative in literature that local journalists are merely constrained by external pressures, such as financial dependency and editorial control (Sharma, 2012; Abernathy, 2020). While these factors undeniably impact journalistic practices, the findings indicate that journalists in Central India adopt various strategies to mitigate these pressures, such as diversifying their funding sources and leveraging digital platforms to amplify their voices and reach broader audiences. This finding suggests a more complex picture of resilience and adaptability, challenging the notion that local journalism in news deserts is solely shaped by external constraints.

6.0 Conclusion

Overall, the study contributes new perspectives to the understanding of journalism in news deserts by highlighting the active and multifaceted roles played by local journalists in Central India. These findings not only affirm existing literature on the economic and operational challenges faced by journalists but also expand on the understanding of their roles as advocates, educators, and boundary-spanners in underserved communities. By revealing the adaptive strategies employed by these journalists, this study challenges existing theories that depict them as passive actors in a constrained media environment, offering instead a more dynamic view of their contributions to local news ecosystem

6.1 Limitations of the Study

This study, which utilized episodic interviews and thematic analysis to explore the role of local content producers in addressing news deserts in Central India, has several limitations:

1. **Subjectivity in Data Collection and Analysis:** Episodic interviews and thematic analysis are inherently subjective, potentially leading to incomplete or biased understanding of the phenomena being studied.
2. **Limited Generalizability:** The study's findings are based on interviews with a select group of local journalists from Central India, limiting the generalizability of the results to other regions or countries with different contexts.
3. **Potential for Overemphasis on Common Themes:** Thematic analysis can lead to the overemphasis of certain themes at the expense of less frequent but potentially important insights, resulting in a skewed representation of the range of challenges and experiences faced by local journalists.
4. **Limited Scope of Episodic Interviews:** Episodic interviews focus on specific events or experiences, which may lack a comprehensive overview of participants' overall experiences or the broader context, potentially overlooking systemic issues that affect local journalism on a structural level.
5. **Influence of Interviewer Presence:** The presence of the interviewer during episodic interviews could have influenced participants' responses, affecting the validity of the findings.

6.2 Future Research Directions

To address these limitations and expand upon the current study, future research should:

1. **Broaden the geographic scope and diversity of participants** to improve generalizability.
2. **Employ mixed methods research designs** that combine qualitative and quantitative approaches to mitigate subjectivity and strengthen reliability and validity.
3. **Explore longitudinal studies** to provide insights into how the roles and challenges of local content producers evolve over time.
4. **Investigate the role of corporates** in funding the media organisation
5. **Examine the influence of structural and policy factors** on editorial autonomy and journalistic independence.

6. Focus on strategies for overcoming challenges, providing practical recommendations for journalists, media organizations, and policymakers to support local journalism in news deserts.

6.3. Key Learnings and Contributions

This study provides significant insights into the complex role of local content producers in news deserts, particularly in Central India. A key learning from conducting this research is the realization of the immense challenges local journalists face, including logistical difficulties, financial constraints, and ethical dilemmas. These findings illuminate the precarious balance journalists must maintain between objectivity and advocacy, especially in underreported and conflict-prone areas.

Personally, the research process has underscored the importance of local journalism in fostering community engagement and democratic participation. It has highlighted how local journalists often go beyond traditional reporting roles to act as community advocates and watchdogs, ensuring that marginalized voices are heard. This study also contributes to journalism and media studies by emphasizing the need for a more nuanced understanding of the unique challenges faced by journalists in news deserts. It calls for greater attention to the structural and systemic barriers that impact editorial autonomy and journalistic independence. Moreover, the study's findings advocate for more supportive policies and resources to sustain local journalism, which is vital for a healthy democratic society.

5.6 Conclusion of the Discussion Section

In conclusion, this study sheds light on the critical role of local content producers in news deserts and the myriad challenges they face in bridging informational gaps. The findings underscore the importance of supporting local journalism through policies that enhance editorial independence and provide financial stability. This research not only contributes to the field of journalism by highlighting these unique challenges but also calls for further exploration into the structural factors

affecting local media. By understanding these dynamics, stakeholders can better support local journalists, ensuring diverse and comprehensive news coverage that strengthens democratic processes and community cohesion.

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7.1 Appendix A- Participant Information

Name	Age	Gender	Location	Experience (years)	Notes	Pre/Post Salwa Judum	Length	YouTube Journalism
P1	55	male	Raipur	35	Non-Tribal Journalist	Pre	01:25:33	no
P2	52	male	Raipur	33	Non-Tribal Journalist	Pre	01:06:04	no
P3	41	male	Jagdalpur	15	Non-Tribal Journalist	Post	01:34:28	Yes
P4	33	male	Bijapur	15	Non-Tribal Journalist	Post	01:40:16	yes
P5	47	male	Jagdalpur	29	Non-Tribal Journalist	Pre	01:28:37	no
P6	61	female	Jagdalpur	09	Non-Tribal Journalist	Pre	01:54:24	no
P7	42	female	Bijapur	22	Tribal Journaist		01:02:58	no
P8	25	male	Bastar	5	Tribal Journaist		00:58:12	yes
P9	62	male	Jagdalpur	16	Non-Tribal Journalist		00:53:22	no
P10	34	male	Dantewada	13	Tribal Journaist	Post	01:21:28	no
P11	31	male	Dantewada	11	Tribal Journaist		00:50:59	no
P12	56	male	Jagdalpur	15	Tribal Journaist	Post	00:54:11	no
P13	36	male	Bijapur	18	Non-Tribal Journalist	Post	01:04:37	no
P14	36	male	Jagdalpur	21	Non-Tribal Journalist	Post	01:18:19	no

7.2 Appendix B- Consent Form

XXXXXXX

[Department of Psychological and Behavioural Science, LSE]

Pre-interview

Hi, my name is XXXXXX, and I'm a Student at the London School of Economics.

[show School ID/business card]

As explained in the information sheet I sent/gave you, I am researching The implications of News Deserts for Central India – Interviewing Local Content Producers

Before I ask for your agreement to participate, I'd like to tell you more about how your information will be used and what your involvement will include. Is it ok with you if I record this?

[wait for acknowledgement]

First, this study has undergone ethics review in accordance with LSE's Research and Ethics Policy Procedure. The information you provide will be anonymized and confidential, which means your name and any identifiable details will not be used in my dissertation. You can retract any information you provide up to 01st August, 2024 without any reason. And during the interview, if any questions make you feel uncomfortable, you do not have to answer them.

If that's all clear and alright with you, are you happy to proceed with the interview? It should take approximately 60mins

[wait for acknowledgement]

And is it ok for me to audio record the interview? This is only to help me write notes/transcribe afterwards. I will then delete the recording.

[wait for acknowledgement]

Do you have any questions before we begin?

[potential interviewee responds]

Post-interview

Thank you so much for your answers. To confirm, are you happy for me to use this information you provided for my [dissertation] with the terms outlined before? I'm also happy to go through them again.

[interviewee reconfirms/asks for details of the study or how data will be used to be repeated]

Thank you so much for your time!

7.3 Appendix C- Recruitment Message

Hello [Name],

My name is [Your Name], and I am conducting a research study on the challenges faced by journalists while working in Bastar. This research is part of my studies at the London School of Economics. I would like to request about an hour of your time for an interview. Would you be available to participate?

Thank you for considering this request.

Best regards,
[Your Name]

7.4 Appendix D- Topic Guide

Introduction (5 minutes)

1. Introduction:
 - Introduce yourself and explain the purpose of your research.
 - Briefly describe what you mean by “news deserts” and why you are interested in their perspectives.
 - Obtain consent for recording the interview and assure them of confidentiality.

Section 1: Background and Role (10 minutes)

2. Background:
 - Can you describe your role and the most important responsibilities you have as a journalist in Bastar?
 - What types of stories do you usually cover?

Section 2: Understanding and Defining Their Task (15 minutes)

4. Defining a Successful Story:
 - In your experience, what makes a news story successful or important? Can you share an example of a story that you feel was particularly successful or impactful?
 -
5. Measuring Impact:
 - How do you know if your work is having an impact? Is it through feedback from your readers, changes in the community, or something else?
 - -
6. Challenges in Reporting:
 - What are the biggest challenges you face in reporting news here in Bastar? How do you overcome these challenges?
 -
 - What specific barriers do you face in accessing information or reaching your audience, and how do you address them?
 - Can you talk about how you approach reaching both Hindi-speaking and Gondi-speaking communities in Bastar, especially considering that many Gondi speakers may not be able to read or write? What challenges come up in this work, and how do you deal with them?

Section 3: Specific Episodes and Their Significance (20 minutes)

7. Episodic Example 1:
 - "Can you tell me about a news story you've reported on in Bastar that you found particularly challenging or impactful? What was the story about, and how did you approach it? Looking back, how does your approach to this story compare with how you might have handled similar stories earlier in your career?"

Section 4: Reflections on the Broader Media Landscape (15 minutes)

9. Role in the National Media Landscape:
 - How do you see your work in Bastar fitting into the broader national media? Do you feel that your stories complement, contrast, or fill gaps left by the national media?
 - Have you ever felt that your work was misunderstood or overlooked by larger media outlets? Can you give an example?
 -
10. Ethical Dilemmas and Editorial Control:

- Have you ever faced a situation where you wanted to report something important, but your editor or publisher did not support it? How did you handle that?
- How do you balance your own journalistic values with the expectations or constraints of the media organization you work for?

Section 5: Looking Forward (5 minutes)

11. Future of Journalism in Bastar:

- "Given the challenges of reporting in a place like Bastar, often described as a 'news desert,' how do you see the role of journalism evolving here?"
- How do you see your role evolving in the coming years?

Closing (5 minutes)

12. Final Thoughts:

- Is there anything else you would like to add that we haven't discussed?
- Thank the interviewee for their time and insights

7.5 Appendix E- Code Book

Global Theme: 1. Boundary-Spanning Roles			
Organizing Theme	Basic Code	Description	Example
Perception of Their Role	Journalism as Duty	Local journalists view their work as a personal and civic responsibility, going beyond professional obligations.	"To me, it feels like a duty... I have the ability to be the voice of millions whose voices are not heard." (P1)

	Advocacy and Representation	Journalists see themselves as advocates for underserved communities, highlighting local issues and injustices.	"We are constantly trying to address the needs of the tribals... if there is any injustice, we write about it." (P2)
Task Definition and Responsibilities	Gathering Local Stories	Focus on collecting and reporting stories from local communities that are often underrepresented by national media.	"We go into the jungle, walk for miles, and bring out stories that are not otherwise told." (P5)
	Balancing Objectivity and Advocacy	Navigating the challenge of maintaining objectivity while also advocating for the communities they report on.	"We don't work with prejudice. If something is wrong, we collect evidence and report it, but if it's good for society, we take a positive approach." (P6)

Global Theme 2. Challenges in Bridging the News Desert

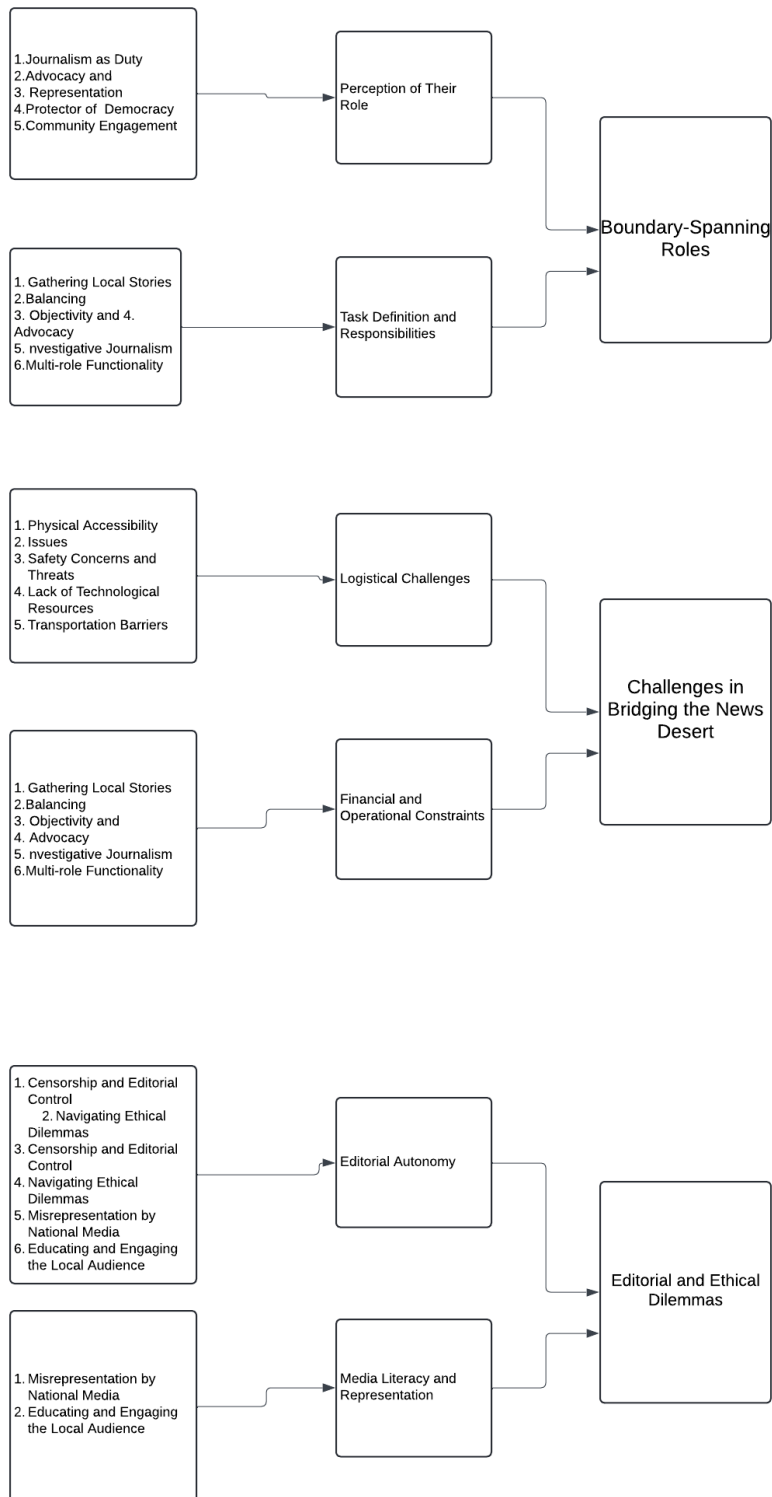
Logistical Challenges	Physical Accessibility Issues	Difficulties accessing remote and often dangerous areas due to poor infrastructure and	"Sometimes we have to walk 50 kilometers to reach a village to
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		lack of safety.	know the reality." (P8)
	Safety Concerns and Threats	Facing risks and threats, including violence from armed groups and intimidation by state actors.	"I have received several threats from the Naxal organization based on my reports." (P9)
Financial and Operational Constraints	Lack of Financial Support	Financial difficulties, such as inadequate salaries and lack of funding, affecting the ability to conduct thorough reporting.	"Rural journalists are not paid adequately... Many institutions do not pay them at all." (P11)
	Reliance on Government Advertising	Dependence on government advertisements, which can limit editorial freedom and influence news coverage.	"If you write against them, they will not like you... they think about removing the reporter from work." (P12)

Global Theme 3: Editorial and Ethical Dilemmas			
Editorial Autonomy	Censorship and Editorial Control	Experiences of editorial interference, including censorship and pressure from superiors or external entities.	"The editor didn't want to publish my stories... It took me a lot of effort to get them aired." (P14)
	Navigating Ethical Dilemmas	Ethical conflicts related to reporting on sensitive topics and balancing truth with community impact.	"Sometimes we have to remain silent if the report could harm the community or incite violence." (P11)
Media Literacy and Representation	Misrepresentation by National Media	Frustration over national media misrepresenting or ignoring local stories, skewing public perception.	"The national media only covers what they think is sensational. They never tell the full story about what's happening here." (P07)

		Efforts to improve media literacy among locals and engage them in understanding and critically consuming news.	"We try to explain to villagers how news is created and why it is important for them to stay informed." (P12)
	Educating and Engaging the Local Audience		

7.6 Appendix F- Data Structure



7.6 Appendix- G Interview Transcript (full)

Interviewer: So, XX, like, um, as I told you, my research is around, uh, News Desert and its implication in Central India, just to give you an idea. So, uh, I walked in this area, uh, for some time with Shanu, and, uh, when I was walking, I could see, like, there is a, you know, lack of news representation, and there is not enough, uh, representation from the Gondi community, uh, which is like lingua franca of the Maest, and during my studies—

Participant: Yes, yes.

Interviewer: Uh, I'm sorry, uh, and then I found that this is the same kind of phenomenon happening in, uh, the US also. Like, after 2005, because of digitization and social—like social media boom, all the brands are, like, they are, uh, diverting their fronts from this small, uh, daily and weekly newspaper to Facebook, Google. And then I saw, like, there's a similar kind of phenomenon happening in, uh, Bastar also. So that what made me curious, like, is there any relation? And how—how do these journalists who work in these areas—how do they operate? What kind of challenges, es—what is the idea of good journalism? And yeah, so that's my motivation basically. So, uh, so before I, uh, like start, like, can you introduce, uh, yourself and, like—sorry, I lost—sorry, can you, like, tell me about yourself and what kind of, uh, stories you usually report? And according to you, what is the—what are the, like, important responsibility you have as a journalist in Bastar?

Participant: Okay, so, uh, I'm an independent journalist. I began writing, uh, purely journalistic reports from 2015 onwards, and, uh, I write for, uh, digital platforms. Um, and, uh, though I had studied journalism long back, I had i' given it a drop, and I moved into the de—development sector. You know, it was good for me to

begin to know the social realities of any place that you're living in, yes. And then, uh, as I moved into actively doing journalistic work, uh, it helped me a great deal to work on this. Now, uh, my, uh, stay—one thing we know that it is important to write about the place that you're living in, yeah. So I had moved to this place, Bastar, which is a conflict area, uh, sometime in 2010–11. Uh, at that time, I was working with the International Committee of the Red Cross. They had started some health and drinking water operations there, and I continued to stay on once their operations, uh, were closed down. Uh, so that sort of gave me also a sense of what was happening in that place. And exactly that—that whatever is happening in the interior areas never reach, uh, in the form of news to people outside. So there was very little information that was firstly coming out. But as I moved into, uh, actively doing journalistic work, what one also realizes it's not just about not getting the news; it's about getting very biased news. Um, so that also, uh, set me thinking. So what is actually happening to the people does not reach the readers. Uh, what is being stated is happening to the people, is being, uh, received as news. So when I started off, one of the biggest challenges was to be able to verify what is being said. And because it's a conflict area and because it is considered, uh, unsafe, logistically also there were a lot of, uh, difficulties reaching those places. Uh, villages were very, very remote. U, uh, so one had to travel on a two-wheeler, have somebody with you to, you know, and also the language. All these difficulties were there to be able to reach, verify the news, and see that whether what is being reported, uh, especially through official, uh, press releases, uh, whether they are correct or not. If you wanted to verify and analyze anything, then you had to visit those places.

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: Uh, so those were the initial challenges. The second challenge was also even if you did reach and come back and report. One of the things that, uh, because those are areas which are, uh, operated by banned political party, uh, it was one extremely difficult to even verify anything from them. Although my concern was

not so much as, uh, what is being stated, because you know that when two political entities fight and struggle, you know that there is going to be a propaganda war.

Interviewer: Yes, right.

Participant: So staying—staying out of the propaganda war is important, uh, to—to me in order to, uh, state facts and truth that was happening to the people there. That was my major intervention, which I continue to do even today, uh, because the idea was not to stay—say what the police or the government is saying or what the CPI Maest is saying, but actually what is happening to the people's lives. That was my interest. So, uh, my interest was to reach the people there and find out what is happening. And over years, what I felt was because there was, uh, very—there were very little reporters who were reaching to find out what exactly is happening, how the people are suffering, what are the kind of difficulties that we find, uh, there was, one, less news coming out. Secondly, there was mistrust on the people who were coming and inquiring. And, uh, so it—it took a lot of time to build your trust. What is this something called journalist or a news reporter? Patria, yes, everybody knows, but patria all always come from the outside, and they come with a world view, and they will never understand me. That was the, uh, the—the notion that they came up. And—and it is true that even today, if the people come out, you know they have moved a long distance honestly. That when the villagers do come and activists do bring them for a press conference and they say that, you know, these are the kind of roads that are being laid, and they are cutting down our trees. You have—

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah.

Participant: —yeah, who ask them, why—why are you opposed to—so what if roads are built? So, this, unless and until, uh, one understands what the people are

living in, it's difficult for so the what the people live there and what the people are outside is very different in terms of the world. So it also was important for me to understand where they are living, how they are living, what are the—what is it that they value, uh, and why is it a violation of that important? Of course, lives and, you know, injuries are all there, but there were also other issues. So yeah, so there's a few challenges and how I came about, uh, them.

Interviewer: Yeah, I'll come to the challenge part later. So, before I, uh, like, move, like, what type of story usually you cover?

Participant: So, uh, one, of course, uncovered stories. Yeah, so, as I said, the primary news was available from the government, especially on the conflict-related matters. Uh, say it was on health services reaching those places or education reaching those places, and also arrests that were being made. Uh, people who are being killed are declared to be Ma. People who are being arrested are being declared as Ma, and people are—so how does Justice C—are they able to reach up to the court? Are they able to—is this—are there the mandatory, uh, magisterial inquiry, which is done? So, how the rule of law operates in a situation like this? And is it suspended? Is it actually happened? And how does the administration and the police function? So those were some of the, uh, around this, my stories, uh, begin to, uh, sort of unravel what is happening there.

Interviewer: All right, thank you. Uh, so in your experience, like, what mine are, like, these news, uh, successful or important—sorry, uh, in your experience, yeah, what makes a news story successful or important?

Participant: I don't know about the successful part, but definitely significant. Uh, I—I mean, I would say the smallest of news is important, and it's for people to—people should know about it.

Interviewer: And can you share an example, like, uh, that you felt like that was, like, particularly impactful?

Participant: Impactful? Yes.

Interviewer: Or important?

Participant: Important to—I see. Primarily, what are news people doing? Now we need to document what is happening because, uh, the kind of news deserts that are there, the truth is never get—never gets documented. It's only after the death of a person do you know that there was somebody by the name of whatever HMA who was living or bu who was alive, and there's no record of that person. There's no photograph; there may not be an—I mean, very recently the Aadhaar card have come, but the fact that an adasi boy or a girl or a man or a woman actually lived on this Earth comes to light only after the person dies, and you know, so, uh, so you start looking at

who these people are, even if, say, for example, I've even, um, looked at when, uh, cers of the Ma die, I also try to look behind what is it that is, uh, pushing people to join the Ma—a so-called banned party which is so risky for them. Why are families sending them? Why are, uh, you know, youth at such a tender age go and join them? What is it that attracts them? Why is it that the government not able to—so some of the background thing also will begin to wonder because U see I'm also person who has studied sociology. Know to see how society is evolving is important. And especially in a—in a place like Bastar, where there seems to be little concern of the government, uh, and, uh—

Interviewer: Yeah, exactly.

Participant: So the important part, I feel, is documenting what is exactly happening so that at some point, you know, people look back at what exactly—when—I mean, uh, 20 years from now, the region is going to be very different. Uh, there might be, um, instances where people might want to look back at what actually happened, and therefore it's important to—I see my role as somebody who documents certain things and, you know, seeks certain answers and raise some questions. I—it's limited to that extent. I'm not looking at a great impact of, you know, somebody gets, uh, like, you know—

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: —uh, happen.

Interviewer: Yeah, yes, yes, I get. Uh, so what I'm trying to basically understand, like, is like, how—how journalists work in these areas, uh, like, uh, you know, like there's a very individualistic view about a successful story, or you can call it an important story or—or—or an impactful story. So, so, and it's—I have seen, like, uh, all these, uh, uh, like, in—in, like, people whom I interviewed, like everyone has a very different view. So I'm trying to understand, like, what is your, uh, you know, like, in your experience, like, how do you see, uh, like, what is good journalism for you? And if you can give me one example that, like, which you have done.

Participant: Good journalism is to reach those places and get the fact out.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: So, for instance, in a situation of conflict here, if the—if the, uh, if there is a news or a press release, uh, from the police that they have, uh, killed about so many Ma and they have arrested so many Maes and, you know, great work with the police, it's important to see. And then very soon you also hear voices of, you know, in—there are some local news who at least bring out the voices of the people who say that there was a huge crowd of people who had come to take the bodies of the people, but they were stating that they were not Maus.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: There would be a simple sentence like that.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: So—and my deeper dig begins.

Interviewer: Yeah, can you share one s—story, like, when you saw a, like, press release and—and then you went to verify it?

Participant: So yeah, I mean, the recent one which I also published, the incident in Bijur, where, uh, 13 people were said to have died. The news was coming very slowly, you know. Initially, they said five people had died. Then they said eight people. Then they said 10 people. Then they said 13 people. So it was a bit of a, you know, as we were in touch with the local journalist and said [___], what is this?

You know, how come an incident which has taken place in at one particular time the news report would say that the firing happened from this time to this time, and how come that you've not either known exactly how many bodies you've recovered?

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: And so it's coming at a very slow pace. So that's sort of, uh, so the press releases which were coming almost every, say, morning 1 and afternoon and late evening 1 was becoming, you know, making you feel a little suspicious of what is happening. Sometimes the photographs are shared. Then you see the age of the person looks young. Then you see, you know, the uniform looks very loose. It looks as if it has been worn—worn on the body. Uh, sometimes they don't show the full body. Uh, sometimes—so this is always happening with the—with this particular incident that I covered, uh, very recently. And, uh, then I started getting calls from the villagers saying that so and so, so and so, so and so, so and so, so and so, so and so have actually—are not Ma, but they have been killed. They have been driven out of the house. They've been picked up from the house. So—so this happened on a particular day on the 2, and I knew that on the 4th, the, uh, villagers were reaching all together to collect the body because they—many people didn't know whether the bodies were there in the morg or whether they have run away out of fear or whether they've been arrested.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: And therefore I also reached around the same time along with other people and started recording that.

Interviewer: All right.

Participant: Um, to—to see what is happening. And then when—okay—in the chaos, when people are losing lives, they are not sitting and giving interviews. So you need to step back a little bit and allow them to settle down with some of the news. You also inquire with the police what happened, inquire with the, um, administration. And then after 2 days, I went back to collect a more detailed kind of stories, what exactly happened, and so—and then yeah. And so you—13 is a large number, no, and people are scattered across and reaching your places are difficult. So by the time you reach, you reconfirm. So see, this is—these are stories which, uh, the police has declared something, and, uh, it becomes very difficult for people to withdraw, uh, the police to withdraw, uh, though mandatory, uh, mandatory judicial inquiry does happen, uh, magist inquiry, not even—sorry—judicial, magal inquiry does happen, but those take little time, and the police is very, very, uh, reticent in giving details of the news. And therefore collecting news from the people and then verifying it further, it took me a long time to verify it back because at one point, the police said the two peoples have not been identified. So who are these two people? Have the bers been taken? So when you start asking the, uh, t said, can you—can I have the list of all the names that you have collected? They would say no, this is for inquiries. It has gone somewhere. You call up later. We can't give you the information, you know, so it—it really gets delayed. And, uh, it was—it was difficult for me to find out. And then you also get the Ma is coming up with their own announcements in their so-called statement. So you compare that also. Then you look at what the people are saying. I—I give a lot of importance to what the people are saying and then compare it to what the police is saying, compare it what they saying, and then sort of write because you have to be very sure of what you're writing because the police is also, uh, do not want to be defamed, right? So they are very particular about whether you're saying it without any evidence, and my people who publish my stories, uh, are also very particular because, you know, these days journalists face a lot of problems and this—

Interviewer: Sorry, I'm making show my—

Participant: I'm saying that I take extra caution, uh, to ensure that my—the—the whatever statements I have is verified thoroughly, uh, you know, by different sources in order to then put down the story rather than just narrating a version because it's a matter of life which has been lost. So the whole question about how was a person killed—it's almost like a crime case, no? So—

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: One has to be very very careful about it. So yeah, one, long drawn process and, secondly, verification and then going back and forth on information and then even reaching out to those villages are very far. So my—you know, getting them back onto the phones become difficult.

Interviewer: Uh, so, um, so with these press—so over time, you also sort of begin to learn the pattern which is emerging. So in this case, the similar thing happened, since we saying that—I as an example I'm just sharing this.

Participant: Yes, yes.

Interviewer: So you see what press notes are being released, and then you start diving deeper into this.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: This is also very interesting because, uh, many of the journalist also shared similar, uh, you know, experiences around press note and validify, and some opposite, like, because it makes people lazy what you are publishing, uh, without verifying. And, uh, also, like, the way you said this, like, uh, verifying the—I was just curious, like, you know, I'm just curious, this—like in a, like, conflict zone, there must be, like, many

incidents happening, uh, on a daily basis or on a weekly basis, but, uh, like—and how do you get this hunch that there must be something to see?

Participant: Uh, as I said, some of the patterns that you see and, uh, uh, sometimes you get often. Now, by now, people know, uh, there are a few journalists who are interested in listening to people, so you also get phone calls.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: Uh, recently there's this—just an hour back I got news that on the 10th of August, a girl got raped when she had gone to do her, uh, farm work, and, uh, so I just got us a news and I said, okay, do you have any contact? Do you know somebody? So I reach out also. So has a case been registered? Uh, so I would also call of the—the concern Tana in charge to say, you know, whether the case has been registered? Do we have details of it and things like that? So yeah, so one is some of the hunches that you get, some of the calls that you get where people call up to say that then you get a detail of it, what exactly happened? When this happened? So in terms of errors, I get very, very regular call, almost morning and evening. Some 10 people have been picked up by the police, and they have been kept there, two have been released, others have not been released. Yesterday, last night, I got a call that somebody has been picked up. So, uh, yeah, so now people know, then they reach out and speak. And then at that point of time, we also call up

the police to say—tell them that, you know, I got a call, these are the people who are ared, can you confirm?

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: Uh, um, of course. Now, uh, my job is not to—

Interviewer: Yeah, um, sorry, sorry, finish.

Participant: I—I—yeah, so I said my job is not so much so as to intervene, but, uh, it's also to understand how it gives me an insight into the fears that people go through. So they would say—so I also tell them, tell the police that, look, this is a fear that they are expressing. So once you confirm, then you know I make a record of all these calls. I make a record of, uh, notes, you know, of how many people get arrested, how are they then declared as surrendered from some place? I mean, yes. Um, there was similar such case where people were taken in from a village, shown as arrested in some other place. Then I called up the police and I said that look, this is what the villagers are saying because I need to verify that also with the police, uh, to say. So you get a response saying no, that is a different case, this is the different case. We've done a different kind of an F, so this is—this is what we have. So, you know what is happening.

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: So, uh, uh, I was reading about your this series, uh, uh, you are writing on scroll also. I—I know about your work. So, uh, so when I was, like, talking to a journalist, like, mostly those who are, you know, like, because, uh, when you were

writing on a national platform, like, there are many kind of reactions to it, and some are good, some are bad, but when, uh, like, good reactions also leads to another kind of, uh, you know, like, changes happening and, uh, this thing, and in all these chaos, if I may say it, like, uh, reaction and, you know, people, uh, interacting with that news and it's having its own, um, for—so how do you know that if your work is having an impact?

Participant: So, one, the thing is when the—when I talk to the police about it, they, uh, you know, when I sort of pro deeper and deeper, and then they yell back at me, saying that, oh, we—I know what you're going to write. Last time also you wrote like this, like this, so you have been really been not been understanding of us. So I know that they read, number one. M, uh, I—I know that. I mean, I also come to know from local journalists when they say that, you know, the police was asking why were you in those areas? What story are you following? So you know that, okay, the authority is also watching you.

Interviewer: Yeah, yes.

Participant: So, uh, when you know that the authority is watching you, yeah, you can either be fearful or you can be, uh, you know that—you know that you're pursuing the right thing, you know. They don't want you to inform you. You actually know that there's a barrier put up, and they come know that I'm going to travel, and they put up a barrier, and then anyway, you find another way to—you al. So I'm saying that the fact that the, uh, authorities does not want you to reach the news and the fact that villagers want you to reach to the news, they may go out of the way to, you know, take you through another forest path to say the parents do want you to meet, meet and, you know, then they want to do the bual. So I'm saying that now I do not know what it—what happens to the people once they narrate it, but I think they feel that they have made a statement of what is right and wrong to them and, uh, you know, in all the truthfulness. So the impact that I see is that as more and more people trust you with their information, uh, I know that

sometimes there are some districts Sps who just do not respond to your phone calls. They just leave you hanging there, so you know that they—so, I mean, that's my one fact. Then also you have—I'm not on social media platform to know exactly, you know, whether people are trolling you or whether people are appreciating you. I don't want to get distracted into that because I just want to focus on these. And sometimes people reach out, write to me emails, write to me, send a message to me. A lot of people have the number saying that this is good, you know. That's the—I mean, the readership looks at the news, I feel. And the in terms of the impact within the region, uh, the fact that 2016 happened, uh, where, you know, and—and the stories they did not want the stories to be out, uh, sort of, you know, makes you feel that yes, this is the—are stories which they would rather, uh, be covered as it is being stated by the police or the administration and not—I've been told that news—take news—what is the reason for it? Uh, so there you have—you know that they would—yes, fear that they could be—so—and there have been instances—I do not know whether it is because of the coverage. There have been instances of, uh, people being, uh, transferred from the places. So one doesn't know. Yeah, I don't want to put too much importance onto the sum of story, but—

Interviewer: Yeah, that's also interesting impact, I say, like someone, like in our Indian system, got exped—

Participant: Well, I don't—not know if you followed the recent one where two—four journalists from Dada Sukma have been arrested. The ti has been put behind bars. So the—the fact that the journalist RA in noise have—so there's also very interesting story, uh, yeah. Uh, so, uh, like, as they say, you know, like, keep—because you—you—you started here, uh, because you saw all these stories and you saw there is a gap. And, uh, so, uh, how do you—you know, learn or, like, how your feedback loop get completed?

Interviewer: I didn't get you—how do I—

Participant: So, like, everyone of us, like, we as individual person, we have a, like, feedback loop, uh, like, uh, we write, uh, like, for me, I can say, like, uh, like I write something, and then my professor will read it, and he will give me feedback, and then from there I learn it. Uh, some journalist I spoke to, they say, like, they talk to their editors, and they have this editorial control, and from there they learn it. And there are many ways of, uh, some journalists say, like, uh, their feedback loops get complete, uh, when they do some mistake, uh, in many ways, uh, like, I won't take name, like, one said, like, uh, uh, like, one said, like, I started off because I want to make money here, but when I—I saw, like, people, you know, like—so that was a learning for me.

Interviewer: Because how your feedback loop you, like, you gets complete?

Participant: How do I take feedback? I mean, yes, the editor defin—the editor definitely—I mean, you send your draft and, uh, I mean, because it's a conflict-related stories, and they know my background and also there can be consequences, they are, like, very th—they ask me the, you know, most difficult—know,

you know, you say that you has tried the talking to the highest authority in the police last 15 days or something, not got a response, sent a message, not got a respon—try again. So, you know, so one is this whole thing of getting the complete picture is important. So those are the kind of feedbacks. And, uh, uh, yeah, my or always seeks response or, you know, they send me a lot of queries about—and it's—it's always nice because somebody who's sitting there, uh, outside, you know, zoomed out of that whole situation, you can be so sucked into this one single incident, a person who zoomed out but also knows the situation brings in a very, very critical, uh, query. So I find that very useful to—oh, [___], I should have looked at that. I should have probably contracted this also, should—so those are—that—that is the reason why the article then gets shaped in that fashion. So those

feedback are there. And I also send it back to the, uh, people and I asked them that, you know, are you okay if I'm—if I give your name and I'm quoting like this? You should—are you fine with that? Whether it is an authority, whether it is a villager, they would say that no, we don't want to be quoted. So I do take feedback from them about, um, to make sure that their security is, uh, they don't feel insecure about talking. Sometimes I talk to doctors who have done postmortem, and they say that, look, we can't be officially quoted, we're going to be—

Interviewer: Sorry—

Participant: Want—I'm saying that even if my—I'm saying that in a situation of, uh, this kind of reporting, uh, you want to make sure that you're not, uh, putting people's lives in danger or getting people to lose their jobs if they—their government jobs and all that.

Interviewer: Yes, absolutely. So initially, you talk about this challenges, like, logistical, language, geographical, and there are others, like, uh, so for you, like, what are the, like, biggest, uh, challenges, uh, like, I—there's no orderly challenges, but like, you know, like, if you can talk about some of the biggest challenges you face while recruiting—

Participant: The bigger challenge is geography is definitely one, and also reaching the explosives are difficult. And then the—the first primary barricade is put up is by the police. They don't allow you to reach there. So those are some things. Over years, they know you for what you are, and you know, they don't let you reach. So we also say, okay, I'll go back. I'm not breaking the barricade and going, but I'll find another way to go. So that's how I've survived. The other big challenge is, uh, if there are anything that I need to verify from the CPI's party, you know them, you don't—example, uh, there was one—one story which I really wanted to do about

the number of people that they are, uh, killing as news—as, uh, police informers because you can't ignore that also.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Uh, so, uh, I really sought—this was many years back—I really sought the police that please give me a list of the people that you have on record as killed by the Ma. So they gave me the list of it. So obviously, now I needed to go back to those families to find out what exactly happened. Some of the places where I went, it turned out to be untrue. Uh, I also wanted to then to know the party, okay, what—why are you doing this? How many people, according to your own list, have you killed in the last so many places? So that becomes very difficult, no. So, uh, because reaching out to them means that you are reaching—speaking to a banned party, then you could—you could even be, uh, uh, be called as having engaged in, uh, wrong activities. So—and because of my past, because the news that I cover is actually challenging what the government is saying, uh, the—the police suspect you to be anti-government and anti-police.

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: And, uh, so there is always this—in conflict situation, especially in Bastar, is you either with us or against us. And me, you're against them because of the story, they say you're with them. So, I mean, that was the reason why they said that you are a Ma sympathizer and therefore you're going to be writing against us.

Interviewer: Uh, yes.

Participant: So—so these are the challenges, yeah. So how do you speak about truth against the government, against the police, uh, not in general but of that particular incident, um, without getting the wrath of the police or the government against you? So, for example, it's—I applied for a press card, and they made such a big thing about, no, and this and that. I knew they were not going to give me a press card.

Interviewer: Mhm.

Participant: So I had a, you know, little bit of a argument with him, I left it there.

Interviewer: Okay, interesting. So and how do you, uh, like, overcome these challenges, like, you know, like getting tagged as a sympath—

Participant: Continue to do—I mean, I feel that it needs to be covered, I just go.

Interviewer: Yes, and, uh, so one guy wrote, like, you know, like in Maorest, uh, the information, uh, is as protected as capitalist protect his, uh, or her wealth. And it's seriously and jealously guarded and passed on to one to other generation.

Participant: What is—what is protected?

Interviewer: Uh, like the information, uh.

Participant: Uh-huh.

Interviewer: Uh—

Participant: No, I didn't feel it. I feel the—the people who are living in so-called Ma controlled areas—could be because of the years that you're going, and they also know—I have not had problem. I'm—and I—I really trust them with truth. If that person is a Ma, they just say, yes, he's a Ma. If that person is not, they say, no, he's not. If they feel terribly upset about any act of the Ma, they say it.

Interviewer: Okay, okay.

Participant: I—I—I find this something brilliant about the in, and I—they—for them, unlike, I—I—I just feel that they—whatever I—that's my perception of them not having to fear anything. They've gone through so much difficulties in life, and they're like—every day is like—like this. They don't fear having to cover up. There's nothing for them to, uh, you know, safeguard. Yeah.

Interviewer: Their property or something to safeguard in order to tell a lie.

Participant: Yeah, absolutely. To bear—it's to open a life that you do.

Interviewer: Yes, uh, I was talking to one journalist and, uh, the journalist was saying, uh, that, you know, like, once you talk to a villager, they will only tell you that, uh, whether this was a Ma or it was a genuine, and you can—

Participant: Does the same goes with Ma also, like, because the author was talking about, you know, like, information is—Maest world it was—he wasn't, like, directing talking about the, uh, tribals. So that it's very much, uh, it's like private property of capitalism. So the way the capitalist, uh, you know, take care of their wealth or like the property. So, uh, maybe like—do you agree to this fact?

Interviewer: No, no, not at all. I—I mean, the Ma is protecting information about the adasis as if they—like the capitalist will protect the property. I don't—

Participant: Because about themselves.

Interviewer: The Ma protecting information about themselves?

Participant: Yes, yes.

Interviewer: About their strategy, about their movement and, uh, or like about their world.

Participant: See, I have not gone into what they're doing, how do they—how are they strategizing now to fight the Indian government? That's not my concern. That's not my field of journalism that I'm covering right now. So I—it doesn't even matter to me. I'm looking at what is happening to people's lives.

Interviewer: Yes, yes. So you also, like, talk about, like, you know, like verifying information and some police and the other parties. And what specific barriers do you face in accessing information or like verifying information?

Participant: Both ways. When the—the—the government doesn't talk to you, the police just refuses to interact with you. Even the basic information that you want. So that becomes difficult. Uh, like, for example, if you say that, okay, the—I mean, how many camps are there? They—they will never say it.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: They don't say, oh, this is—no. So if you say, okay, how many people were there who had gone for this—no, no, security reasons we can say. So, I mean, I just don't understand why. I mean, I—long back, I remember I sent an RTI because they were not responding. I sent an RTI to say that, okay, can you tell me how many finally got killed, how many arrested, how

many this thing. So, no, we are—we—we don't—we can't give you that—actually quoted a section, so and so, for security reasons. I thought—so basically they didn't want to give any information. What we are saying is, I said, but every year you announce SS, you know. Can you just want to put a consolidated report to say that in the last 5 years, this has happened? Yeah.

Interviewer: It takes the 11—

Participant: But I said I can wait in the last five years. So, such and such has happened. You also put record and you want authentic report. No, not just about

gathering fromp or some, you know, press reports and what—what is it that—so those—one is that, uh, getting information openly from the police especially. Uh, even in terms of schools. So you say, okay, in the interior areas, how many schools are actually functioning? How many teachers are actually there? They're not willing to give information. I literally go looking for a cluster coordinator because you get some information from the—so is it really—so the website, the school seems to be functioning. There's a teacher also present. I can't just report saying that the villages are saying schools are dysfunctional. No.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: It's unfair to—for whatever government efforts are there. So if I want to ask that, okay, can you please tell us that, you know, whether this school or function—the—the district education officer will say no, can you talk to the block education officer? So when you talk to the block education officer, they'll say, can you talk to the cluster coordinator? A simple, bare information, they really find it difficult to respond to because—is it going to—so that is one part of it. The second part is getting statistics, getting, uh, uh, you know, a full i—I—a single statistic need—need to be backed—quantity needs to be backed by quality information. So I find it very difficult to get quantity information, especially on the kind of stories that are do concrete related stories. So those are from the side of the government. Uh, the verifying truth, reaching the places, uh, is itself—especially if you want to reach the area immediately after the incident, uh, they would say SE operation is on, we won't—you wouldn't be allowed to go and etc., etc. Some journalists—there are embedded journalists, so they do reach to the place and, you know, uh, talk about the incident and come out, which at least that is happening. But no analytical report comes or if you want to even meet the family and talk about it. So reaching out to those places are difficult. I don't see the difficulty of talking to people, and the people are openly able—willing to share information. That is one thing I should really give credit to, uh, the people in living in those villages. Uh, so reaching the place continues to be a difficulty. And, uh, the third part is, if I need any verification from the CPM party, then reach—you may come across a very low

cer whose information you don't want to fully just—they are also not willing to share. They might say that I'm not the right person to be talking about. Yes, so reaching to the people becomes very difficult, uh, especially if you want to verify—like, I shared one of the that as—how—how many number of people have you killed and assaulted and as police informers? Can you give me a list of the people? And then I wanted to actually do a story of those families who been asked to leave, who been asked to—who one of the members have been killed, etc. So verification in that sense becomes difficult, but since I rely most, um, mostly on the—on what people go through, I verify it with the people, the reles, and directly with their family members.

Interviewer: Not—not—yes, uh, I was—I wanted to know about the—because, uh, the other journalist I spoke to, like, they're like writing in Hindi, so people in—like, the villagers and others, like, they could, you know, understand, like—like, there are one villager in v, uh, in the village, like, they talk about like, uh, someone in Jagalur wrote about you. But as you are, like, writing in English, and you are approaching a community where the literacy rate is not that high, so—and—and they don't—like, most of them, they don't know, uh, you know, like, they're not connected to the internet. Uh, so h—how do they know about, like, uh, what is getting reported about?

Participant: Yeah, that is a difficulty, no doubt. That is a difficulty. But wherever I can, I share it back with them. There are a lot of young school children who have it—who have their—I do take a phone number once I leave, and they always—and I also tell them as—in fact, immediate report, I'm not the right person for that. I will come—I will—but I will—my writing will take a little longish time. And also, Ang will—and my audience is different.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Uh, one of the problems with English, uh, now, the YouTube and social media is enabling people to read beyond your own little region. But otherwise, print media, it gets lost, that particular district, no? Uh, so that is the other aspect of the news desert that is being cre. So I—and if I'm just holding a newspaper, I do not get to know what is being reported in ker, what is getting reported in Sukma.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Uh, unless and until I reach out to those edition. Uh, so those are all killed in the district itself. They never reach rur.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: And, uh, and because, uh, I feel that al also, even if people are able to say that they come to the tana and they were claiming that these people who were killed were not Ma, the news will flash, but it does dies down there. Um, but if a news goes out—and that is one of the reasons why they wanted to drive me away. But the reach of the audience was that it was getting at a national level that was—could have been troublesome for the government, and they would not want, uh, any news to go beyond a certain region.

Interviewer: Yes, yes, right. And, like, so you spoke about, like, that there is this problem that, uh, reaching out to—reaching back to the, uh, community that what you wrote and, uh, so—but that's a problem, like—and, like, initially, how used to, like, deal with this problems because, you know, like, then they know you less, and they trust you also, they don't also, like, trust you more?

Participant: Uh, see my—I may have visited about 10 incidents of situations, but I may pull out only one article which I tell them honestly also. And, uh, uh, when I share them, if they able to look up at the—because these are all digital news only. So they—sometimes they take a look, and sometimes they look, you know, somebody's photograph has come, or, you know, something has been mentioned.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Uh, so they feel, okay, this has gone beyond, even outside also written in English. In fact, before I quote them I—so yeah, it's a little tough. They can't immediately read up what is being said. Then, uh—

Interviewer: And—and you spoke about this, uh, I think that—that, uh, r story happened, uh, 4th of July, right? Am I correct, last month?

Participant: Which one are you talking about?

Interviewer: Uh, you spoke about the incident, like, where one, uh, girl was raped—

Participant: Ab.

Interviewer: Huh? Yeah, yeah. 10th of—10th of August, yeah.

Participant: Ab.

Interviewer: So—and, uh, so how do you, uh, you know, because you are not, like, daily—you are not part of a daily newspaper, more in-depth and analytical, so—and if you are away from Bastar, and there something important happens, and you reach later, and does that make any, you know, influence, like—or does it—

Participant: Affect the story?

Interviewer: Yeah, affect the story in a positive or, like, negative way?

Participant: So, uh, yes, it affects the immediacy of the story, uh, you know, and—but often stories emerge a little later, you know. At that passionate moment, somebody says something, all that happens. But I've also felt that, you know, people tend to rest when—when rush—when there is a encounter incident and people rush. For example, just to—before I get back to this particular incident, I want to talk about how in, uh, Vapur incident, I know that when we were standing at the hospital where people had come to collect the body, it was so important for me as a j to look at the shock and how the administration was dealing with this large numbers of deaths, and how the bodies were being pulled out of the morg, and how the people were washing the dead bodies, and people had come with—they had literally nothing to sh—to show that this is how my husband looks and just a name, p. And then they were looking whether he's dead,

he is arrested, or he's, uh, in the hiding somewhere, no? So they waited for two days to come back in order to see whether he's actually dead or not. And I know that a large number of journalists had actually gone to the village, and then—

Interviewer: Villagers are not willing to talk.

Participant: Because the people—and then I also decided that let me give another two days for them. See, you have to be also sensitive.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: You have to recover from their shock whether he's been—uh, there's a genuine encounter or not, but the fact that the person is dying, the family needs to be given time to moan the death. People are talking, but it's a little intrusion. So I do do that. Now, in this case, yes, I mean, there are several incidents where you lose the immediacy of the—but in any case, I don't do a very, very immediate—sometimes in protests I do because there is a huge, uh, barricading of the road, or, you know, they have done a chaka jam and the national highway has been—then, yes, there is a need to—or I once did on Badila thing where they had, uh, you know, there was a mining incident, so—but it—and everybody reported saying that the Gr Sabha, the people are claiming that the Grah SAA is fake. But I can't just make a statement, no. My—the report, I had to actually figure out where the Gr SAA report is, then I have to really dig, get the report and—and we could actually put—put it out there that here, the—the Surp punch denies that she has signed, although there is a sign of us. And I took it back to her. I said, look, this is—here is a s—a signature, H. So that made a better impact of the story to say—for the—for one to dig out the document, confirm with the person. So it meant that, yes, I need to make at least two three rounds, uh, to get that verified. But those becomes very difficult for people who are living outside Busta to do it. Uh, you know, it's expensive or little difficult to keep in and out. Local reporters—I mean, I living in Jagalur is still easier to the Russian 3 hours from somewhere and then—

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: —managed to. So—so it has its disadvantage. I don't deny that, that you able to. But what my—my idea is not to do a crime evid is—you know, where was this person. But these are stories which needs to emerge eventually to talk about and, uh, sometimes one in story of a, uh—I—I do not know how this would be. I have to go back and follow up on the story and it actually reach—it also reveals the kind of difficulty an adolescent girl goes through now. Yeah, couple of days back, some—the journalist wanted to do some story and they were talking about it, but said that one incident of abuse, sexual assault in a hostel, girls hostel reveals a lot more things about what is happening in Hostel.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: So—uh, so one can then make a larger picture—a larger story of it. My interest is to l picture, not just about that incident with that incident is just a tip of the iceberg. There's a lot more to it that—

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: —yes.

Interviewer: So then I turn the story to look more deeper, not just go—

Interviewer: So you spoke about this—you know, this, uh, uh, this factor that editor is the one who knows about the, you know, situation, but he is—he has this zoomed out, uh, view. But when we work on these—like, when you work on these,

uh, horrific incident, sometime, like how—what kind of—how your internal dialogues, uh, like, impact your reporting?

Participant: See, uh, one thing is, uh, I don't allow any tampering with the facts. Don't allow that. That's why you are on a—on an as an independent journalist. Uh, you don't allow that. Otherwi—then I'll go somewhere else. But, uh, there are—so it's nice to have editors who know the situation.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Sometimes when I send it to people, they don't even know, like, for example, um, I did one story in Outlook where they said that something—they said—I—they sent me a playback, but I had corrected it. I—certain language I don't use. I don't use things like Maus-infested area. I find—

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: —like mosquito infested.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: But Ma-infested, I find it very difficult to—you can't be interested.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: So, uh, but then they would put it. I didn't send any further check with them. Okay, can this be, uh, can I report again for Outlook? I know there—some instances where people just put out whatever you have sent. I also don't want that, no. I want people to, uh, look at it in a way that—know, can the reader comprehend what I'm saying. Know, my—some of the that I worked with, they said, no, this is getting too long. It is getting too much in detail. We'll have to shorten it because if we—I'm going to lose interest. What are we trying to say in this? Some—so deep into it that you want every emotion to be out—out there.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: And—

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: So at that time, I feel little bad, uh, that you have to actually withdraw some of the, uh, instances—we collected so much—

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: —you know, for instance, 13 people—for each 13th person—person's family, whether Ma or not, or civilians—

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: —have emotions to share, and know that doesn't get necessarily narrated. So you pick up the most important and, you know, something which gives you message. So those are things that happen.

Interviewer: So yes, so—and, uh, so of all these stories, like, what was, like, most challenging for you? Like, you talk about the her and this encounter killings, extra judicial situation.

Participant: Yeah, telling st yet to come out.

Interviewer: And—and how—how—how do you approach these stories? Uh, like—

Participant: Approach means you—

Interviewer: Like, what—what the, like, first thing you do? Like, I know, like, you go to the place, uh, place—that's your first approach, but, uh, like, I'm trying to imagine, like, uh, as a, like, national media journalist, like, who want to do a—you know, like, in-depth story, not something like five killed, 10 injured story. So what is your approach, uh, in—in case—like, can you—

Participant: Reaching the place, number one, and then you pick up some threads of conversation, uh, that is there. And then you rify it from the people. It's basically to verifying the things at the place. Like, for example, somebody would say that but can you come—you don't even have to come right to the village. We'll come to

certain such place. I would say, actually, no, I want to meet the person in the house, in the place that you—you also get a feel of what that place is like. You know, I want to be very sure that I'm meeting the mother, or I'm meeting the sister or whoever. So I need to be very sure of that also. So one thing I make it a point is to as much as possible reach at the place, uh, of the—of the person who affected person, reach the place of incident, which they—unless and until I see it thoroughly with my own eyes and everything—reconfirm back with other people, maybe with the, you know, sources of information that you have, the government to exactly what is it—get an official statement. That's the—that has been approach.

Interviewer: Can you tell me, like, about a story? Because he said, like, most of the time, when incident happens, like, there is a police picking or barricading—

Participant: I lost you, uh, most of the time—sorry.

Interviewer: You said, like, most of the time, they don't all—they don't—the police won't allow you to reach the village, and, uh, and don't—like, so there's a challenge. So can you, like, tell me about one story, like, where reaching the place itself was, uh—

Participant: Difficult?

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Yeah, so I—I had written about it. In fact, article 14 is the place where I covered that story. There—number of civilian deaths that are happening. And later on in article 14, they asked me to give in a field notes. They also have a

section on field notes. So I've written on that also exactly this where there were three people who had been killed.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: I got a call in the forest, and the police killed them. Uh, so I said, okay, uh, I'll—I'll rush out immediately. Right. Uh, it was a very far away place. I know the

roads were there, and then you could reach with that particular—said, I—I—I'm on my own vehicle, so I rushed on my bike. But they said that maybe they will not allow you to come on the main road, you have to find another. So at that point of time, yes, I was not allowed to go up beyond a—they had put out a barricade, and they said, sorry, you can't go. And the family has said that we are holding on to the bodies, we are not cremating or, uh, burying the body until you come. So I felt all the more responsible [] because I kept telling them, no, no, no, I'll reach, I'll reach. And then, uh, they did not let me. So for nearly half an hour, I—by now, you know the pattern, so there's no point. And there have been—initially, there have been times that I keep waiting, no, trusting the police that, okay, they will allow you to go once if they say that the search operation is over and things like that.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: But I waited for half an hour, and they said that—patiently waited for—and I got up and I said, look, I need to—but I had to reach the place. Nothing. I, uh, you know, we went back on the roof and contact another person, uh, from the village and say that, look, I want—want to reach the village. How do I go?

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: Somebody said you can go from this forest far. I said, I don't know the for—can somebody come up to that particular point in order to reach? So villagers who are willing to support you. So they hopped on to—pon riding with me. And then it was a tough ride, no doubt. Yeah, because riding in the forest path is a little tough. I reach and finally reached the place. And there was another reporter who managed to also reach. I was little surprised. How was he allowed to reach the place? And then there is a whole—yeah, so this is the—this is the in—incident not too far back I reported on. And then because I was stopped, article said that can you write about that? So how do you reach to news? It's not that the news was not—was bad. The—the right news was because they had declared the Mouse, and that's it. When I iil what the family was sharing—in fact, one of persons was with the police himself. They said that yes, one of my brothers is with the police, but my young daughter is not. So took the story and spoke to them, spoke to a lot of villages. I had a huge argument with the—and I asked him, this is what the villages are saying, what is your—

Interviewer: Said nothing doing, they're M is all right. So—so what do you think, like, this, uh, higher rank police officer, like, are they not aware of about the ground report—situation, like, ground situation? Or they ignore—they choose to ignore it? Or they have their own involvement?

Participant: Of course, you know the ground situation. They don't want the ground situation to be known, especially if they find that something is a Ma.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: Um, in often you see the, uh—a lot of work is being done through, uh, their—they have particular force called the—

Interviewer: Are all these questions related to news desert? I'm a little surprised—question that you're asking. I understood news desert has to be very different.

Interviewer: Uh, so these are part of, uh, my, uh, uh, like, query of, like, understanding and defining the task. Like, how do you define this—your task?

Interviewer: So—so—so yeah, that's—that's one of my research question. So I—so I'm trying to understand. So these are—so in our term, like, we call it episodic interview, uh, so where you ask the interview about a specific, uh, situation, and then I compare it with the other journalist who—whom they talk, and then there this global things that come out, like, what is actually happening, uh, so when, uh, you know, uh, national media reporter is going there, how they're approaching the stories, and when—how the journalists are approaching the story. So that's part of the, uh, larger, uh, this, uh, understanding of the world.

Participant: Okay.

Interviewer: So as—

Participant: Yeah, as I said, uh, the fact that they were—they don't allow you to go there obviously means that they are hiding certain TRS. I me, why should they know if they are saying that they have killed Ma? Fine, keep it open. I mean, the

bodies are there. You can meet the parents, you can talk to the parents, and, you know, they—they can always say that, okay, these people may say that they are not Ma, but in our record they Ma. So then we say that, okay, in your records, if their Mouse, can you tell us what are the cases against them? So we just say, h, we'll send it to you, we'll share it with you. But it never comes to us. Uh, you also see the, uh, what are the force? Was it the CRPA? What is the BSF? Or what kind of security forces have gone in? And you, by now, you know that CRPF—the central paramilitary forces are bound by certain very, very, uh, strict training. Um, you see a lack of it in very, very locally recruited people because, uh, they have also recruited people from, uh—from locally. Uh, so-called what they call it, the District Reserve Guard, who have surrendered Ma or who have left their villages. They may not necessarily be Ma, but who have been in the village. And then there have been some insts—I—I have a huge, uh, reporter of information on people who have given up there for fear because, uh, it's a community living. So if you have anything, uh, the community is upset about, then they come out of it. Either you have to abide by what they are suggesting or telling you, or if you're defined about it, then they make it difficult for them to do. So they come out of it, and then the only option, unfortunately, for such people, or even for surrender Mes, to join the police.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: And they are then used to gather information and pull out information. I've seen several instances where the DRG—you know, per force, uh, they made to identify—identify people who may have been supporters of the Ma from the village, um, maybe unarmed, uh, the so-called Jan militia. So I've got horrible interviews about them. Then they identify them and they been killed. So they—there are series of secret police G, police, they have. So now once what I feel about the senior officers is once the ACT is committed, you know, so I asked them. I said, look, whether he was Ma, not Ma is—could be one question. H, the other question is that how that person got killed. I mean, there are the—the—the how do you say the—the kind of killings very cruel. And, uh, then you said—then the

senior officers get onto a blanket thing. No, no, no, there was an encounter. They were fired. They fired, you know, that—they put it out in the fire, not willing to listen. And which is what there is—you feel that there is the necessity to, uh, prove that the police has an upper hand on the—over the Ma or that the region is very, very Ma interested, so to see. And therefore, you need more and more military troops, uh, also helps them, and, uh, they sort of allow such acts to go unaddressed.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Which is a sad thing, which needs to—I feel that because when the rule of completely, yes, there is no justice, and, you know, the—how the I—I—in fact, I tell them, I tell people that, you know, people who have said that they innocent M—judicial inquiry who give—you go give a statement, tell them that yes, she is not—he or she is not a M, make a statement.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: The only way that you can, you know, continue to pursue what is there within the—as part of the procedure, you have to follow that.

Interviewer: So—so—so you—once you talk about, like, when you were, like, in your initial days, you used to trust, fly, and—and it's like over the time, like, you—you understood, like, whom to trust and when to trust, and—and like that's the, like, you know, like, uh, how do I say it, like, dynamic, uh, uh, the way you, uh, approach the things. And is there any other changes happened over the years, like—

Participant: What?

Interviewer: —in—in, uh, like, reporting such situation? Like as you gained—

Participant: My—I mean, I never went with the trust of the police. That's not what I'm saying. I'm saying that because they in a position of authority, you would—you would—you would imagine that that person would tell things with you, share things with you from their point of view. Nobody

saying that you have to, uh, so if you say that, okay, so what has happened and—

Interviewer: What—

Participant: Correct me in this—my statement is that, like, I think it was around that used to wait. So—so I was trying to say, like, uh, so trust means when, like, they used to say, and you used to, like, trust their words, uh, that's what I'm saying. But later you understood, like—

Participant: Yeah, I would—see, I would—I would honor what you said. They are the authority there. They are the people who put up a barricade. And I'm going to fight with them. Never did I earlier fight with them, neither am I fighting with them. So they always say, you do your duty, and I'm doing my duty.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: So if you think allowing me is going to have a problem with your duty, fine, because you would say I have to ask the senior—the senior. So that pattern of delay, I began to understand. So half an hour later, I said, whether you speak to your senior or not, I'm leaving. But in earlier time, I would—

Interviewer: [Music] say—not that they do not—

Participant: Know, you know, those are the kind of delays, but by then I do not fall for those delay tactics right now, uh. And even then, and now, even if—when I call a people for—they would say that, so one of the things that, of course, you do your duty. I mean, you feel that somebody suspicious, you have arrested them, fine, you're within your rights to do it. But confirm it, have you arrested them? They say—so once the information is out that they have arrested, you also know that there is a rule that you can't withhold the person in custody beyond 24 hours.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Yes, so—and you can't—there was one instance where I—somebody called from the family and said—first thing you ask, how old was [___]? I said, do you have any proof? So they say they have internet. They're able to come out again and send it. Then I called, said. So then they say—sometimes they will not answer. You know, that can go unanswered. But in this situation, then I reach to another senior level, and I said that, look, a 14-year girl has been taken in, it's evening now, it's 6:00 already, and you want to keep the woman in the Tana, and then by then it will be 12 hours. So I'm just saying that we all know the rules, and you know. So it has sometimes helped, and they keep calling. I would tell them that you also call her from your end, but they fear that the police will start harassing them. That time the police, in that particular intent, they called up to say that, uh, around 6:37, they said, ask the family to take a back far. So I don't know. I said to tell them she might

have the number, said, since inou with. So those things have also happened. Whether—so you honor what they are doing. If they think that they are arresting people and they—they're stopping me, of course I challenge them and I asked them as a journalist, how do you stop me from reaching to the news? There was one protest which I said, and that time I had to literally fight through. He said, no, I don't care.

Interviewer: Interesting.

Participant: So like that. So it's not so much as—uh, you—you wait through it. In that particular incident where they stopped me from going, I knew they would never let me go.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: I had to only reach through another route. So I had to spend few hours to find who can help me find that tru.

Interviewer: Very interesting.

Participant: Like they doing—they doing their duty, founding my duty. I—I don't see any, uh—

Interviewer: And, uh, the next question is—this is around, like, reflections on the border, uh, broader media landscape. So how—how do you see your work in Bastar fitting in into the broader national media?

Participant: So I really wish there's more media—national media coverage. Like, for example, if I look at, um, Hindu, Indian Express, Hindustan Times, um, the other [music] English—it's not that news doesn't get covered in them, but INP news have taken a dip. So there may be bit of analysis, but I seriously feel that, you know, people are not reaching to the location and reporting. And—and, I mean, while you can understand the kind of difficulties they might be finding because, you know, one, the contact, secondly reaching to those places itself is difficult. And if you're hiring a vehicle, then it becomes more difficult. And, uh, I do not know how it is now. I drive on my own, so, I mean, I ride on my own, so I'm fine with it. But otherwise, the first thing that they do do is—the driver is not—driver is being—you know, they stop him, they ask him for their papers, and if he doesn't have one single paper or something, then they stop the vehicle from moving. So your entire—this thing gets problematic. Um, yeah, so—and so in—in terms of national media coverage, definitely needs to be a lot more, and I feel that that is not happening. That really is not happening.

Interviewer: So is it in that sense, uh, you know, if I'm able to cover a bit of it, I get space for that, I'm happy about it. So is it, like, complementary, subsidiary, or, uh, parallel?

Participant: What?

Interviewer: Is, uh, your work, uh, in—in, like, national media?

Participant: Uh-huh.

Interviewer: Uh, so, like, how you see your work with respect to, like, national machinery? Is it, like, parallel, subsidiary, or complimentary?

Participant: Do I respond to that par—I mean, um, um, I—I—I know—I—I—I don't fully understand your question.

Interviewer: So, uh, like, uh, do you—like, does your sto—do you feel that your story is, like, complement, uh, or contrast, or fill gaps, like, left by the national media?

Participant: So, uh, there could be a news item that an incident has happened. So I may refer to, say, an article that this incident has happened, you know, as reported in h—thean Times or ind Express, but I go much beyond that. So I think I—I—I go far beyond that.

Interviewer: All right. All right.

Interviewer: Have you ever felt that your work was, like, misunderstood or overlooked by larger media outlets?

Participant: Misunderstood by the—

Interviewer: By the government?

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: Larger media outlets.

Participant: So I—I do feel sometimes that, you know, like, uh, conflict stories or probably any story for that matter, I find it very difficult to report in very short. You—I feel the pain is so much and which needs to be done. So I—I sometimes feel that, uh, not getting enough space—place to write is a—I feel one loses out on the tar narration. The second part is that, um, uh, in one outlet which I had, uh, written, I had written about the court procedures, and I felt that it was very important to see that what the arguments were all about, and where is it—how is it that, uh, what is a narrative that is being put across from the government side, and what is the narrative that the people side was putting a AOSS? And—and I found it very fascinating how the—it was not so much about the incident, but more about the perception which was being created. And I wrote about it because I attended a few quot, uh, instances. And somehow I—I—I could never publish it because I didn't get that space. They—they said, no, no, but can we check with the people, how they feeling about the loss and all? I said that part was not so much about the incident, that part was more about—that—that's an old story which has already been reported. But how is the, uh, government justifying it, and how are the people, uh, talking about pain? That I felt, and how the judge was listening to both the sides. Now, and the anticipation of an order that I found us very, very fascinating to see how you discuss. But, yeah, so I—I do feel pained, and when somebody says, no, can we—can we have, uh, you know, check with the people? B—it's not so simple checking the people, going there, coming back. It'll take probably a week, no? And somebody has gone off to for some labor work, so there are no phone calls to make an inquir. And, in fact, and—and there are many instances where my editor said, has it—have you personally visited? Is there a—is there a phone call? In some cases, if it's a phone call, they just say, sorry, phone call, please go and check with them. And I know that the person spoken is genuine, but we still need to have a very, very face-toof—face contact. So I'm—

I'm agreeable to that, but I'm happy to—to take that extra mile and know actually visiting people. But sometimes the story—you can't—there are various angles to the stories which needs to be reported.

Interviewer: And that can you also talkot proceed their thing, like, if—if you don't want, like, to name the media house, like, that's okay. But if you can talk about that ced—

Participant: No, I don't want to because it's an unpublished story and—

Interviewer: All right, no worries. So, uh, so then next question is about, like, uh, editorial control. And have you ever faced a situation, like, where you wanted to report something important, but your editor or, uh, on the similar lines of the previous—

Participant: Yeah, I remember i' done one story, and, uh, my editor—the—the—the news agency that I had written to, they said that, look, uh, this has already been, uh—this is only a order, uh, of the National Human Rights Commission that we are almost like, no, representing. Okay, what's the point? What is it? So I said, no, read through it carefully. Know, we actually saying that each order has been ignored, and what is the final order? So I had to say that, okay, then they got the—this thing and said. So sometimes it works, uh, to put—push exactly what you're looking at, uh, what you—what you want to stay. Um, editorial control, uh, some—sometimes language, as I shared with you, this whole interested and affected, those kind of things—fin, you can't do anything about. Then you also say digital news, you can say that, no, this is not—sorry, but can you change it?

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: Uh, sometimes, um, when I have, uh, you know, the chief editor agrees with the story and, uh, gives me a quick feedback, uh, the person gives me good feedback, and that person then hands it over to a Editor to do the editing bit, then I have some problem. Then I do have problems at that point of time to say, no, no, no, but why is this being narrated here and it needs to come below. So sometimes, yeah, so those difficulties are there. And, uh, you do—or in terms of place and all—know the name of the village, the distance and all that. But they don't understand so well. So even the fact that traveling 8 kilometers, walking down 8 kilm becomes a very difficult thing to explain now. So how do you say that, you know, that patient walked 8 km over there—8 km is nothing somewhere sitting in—in a bigger city.

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: So those are the kind of things to push through. Uh, sometimes they miss out that, and you have to—you would also missed it in the larger part of—said [___] I wanted to share that, but that got completely miss—ed. Found it very trivial to say that person went for 8 kil—what the big deal?

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: So, yeah. So those are some final things.

Interviewer: And how do you handle—like, one you talk about, like, you let them, like, you know, like, explain the whole thing about NSRC report and so—so is

there any other way you handle such situation, like, where you don't get enough support?

Participant: Uh, say, say, for example, the photographs they use to depict something. There are lot of, uh, um, agencies, uh, who have their own set of photographs, right? And I do click my photographs. So sometimes, even when you send it, they prefer to choose something else. And then in the final publishing, they put out a photograph, and I to write to them, I said, I don't agree with this photograph. It doesn't depict and it's a general—from the thing. But, I mean, politely, I say that, well, now that it is—it's in print, you can't do anything about it. I don't know what to do, but I—I—I do make more point. It has happened in two such situations. I did not agree with the kind photograph put out and didn't—

Interviewer: Yeah, I—I remember I saw one of you—uh, one of your story, it was around, like, when this journalist were, like, uh, facing, uh, this death, uh, threats from Ma and this photo of Pusa R and—and the all—all these boys, like, how they—with all the Asing, you know, and that really—and that newspaper that—I remember that guy was holding in his hand. So, uh, I think it was a newspaper. And that was very, you know, like, people don't, like, notice, but it's a very important, like, powerful story that holding a newspaper, you are looking at a digital something because c journalist. And so, yeah, I—I—I could imagine, like, this is very important to have—have all this, uh, yeah, check and balances in place. And—and, like, the first thing is that, uh, like, we are almost on the end, uh, that, uh, like, all the media organization you—you work with, they have their own set of, uh, journalistic values and expectations, and you have your own journalistic values and expectations. And it—it's natural to, you know, like, sometimes these are not same. Uh, and—and how do you balance with that?

Participant: Um, at one point, at one—in one case, uh, when I was asked to relook at the piece, bring in this aspect and that aspect.

Interviewer: This—sorry, this—

Participant: [Music] this—

Interviewer: So—

Participant: Got this additional few pieces, uh, yet seeing that it's too long. I said it doesn't go because if I additionally look at more information, uh, then it becomes too much—more information with lengthier piece. And I said, I—I—I find it very difficult to—and then when—when lot of things—important things gets chopped off in order to keep the length as suitable as possible. And also, you make a lot of effort, no, to explore those things. Lot of print media wants statistical information. I tell them it's not easy getting statistical information because the authorities do not share so openly. Uh, so the—at one point, I just stopped giving to those people. What to do, know, if it doesn't match with your, uh, what the—the story line that you're putting out? M, there was such—and said that I gave a large long gap. I did not write only. And then finally, the next time I wrote to them, they said, no, no, no, we value what you're writing. Please go ahead. I gave them a small pitch because I had done a large part of it, so I then shared with them, and then they give me a really good free hand to write. No. So I think engaging is important to explain, uh, and you get only incidental news or any big event happens—any bit—but you don't get a more deeper. So I don't feel that people are interested in, uh, in news, um, but so long as it takes a certain line that they want to, they would be happy to keep it.

Interviewer: All right.

Participant: And then with this kind of thing, if I engage and tell them this is what you want, tell—what to do.

Interviewer: So, uh, so, like, talking about—you know, walking in these areas, like, because, uh, you—you talk about—you spoke about that, uh, you know, like, idea of, you know, journalist coming in and going out, like, uh, parachute journalism. But you not—you stay there, and you talk to the people, and you go there and—and you have your own, you know, understanding of the situation. So—and—and the truth about the place, uh, so what important, uh, like, truth or fact about walking in these area, uh, very few people agree with you, uh, this whole, um, the perspective?

Participant: Okay.

Interviewer: Uh, like, for example, I remember I had an—a little argument with the—a local news person from Jagdalpur. And he said that police—one person said that we do have to manage a balance. We have to work that tight rope so that nobody gets angry with us. I don't agree with that.

Interviewer: Right.

Participant: The other person said that we all agree, yes, there are a lot of things that the police and the administration do are wrong, but can't keep writing about that only that. I said, for that the DPR is there, no? They have that—their job is to put out good—good work that the police or the administration is doing. That's not my job. I'm not a d. So I said, so, yeah. So the perspective with which one comes, uh, or the perspective which comes out in the writing—and always tell them, I'm not cooking of these stories. These are fact stories. I who talk to the administration

and the police, and they know exactly what I'm talking about, writing about. I—in fact, text them this—it is about this incident that I wish to discuss with you. Tell me a suitable time to speak.

Interviewer: No. So I—I do not hide anything from—

Interviewer: I know that given the challenges in reporting in such play, uh, uh, how do you see the role of journalism evolving here—you—please B.

Participant: Yes, yes. I—there is—there is a need to flex your journalistic space. And I'm very happy with the fact that a lot of local journalists know they—they do share that, uh, in the media where they working because a lot of media friend are, uh, having either the business interest or they have to rely on the advertisement that they get from the government—this heavy competition. Uh, so lot of news which are—goes against the police is not published. They—they've been asked not to publish the stories, or they just keep lying there. So people have also taken the rout of starting their own YouTube channel. Uh, so there is a huge bursting of YouTube panels that are happening from Buer—you might have noticed also. So people—there have been good reports, uh, by the YouTube journalist. I wouldn't that at all. At le—the first part of the information comes out—the difficulty of putting out very analytical news may be a difficulty, but, uh, reportage terms of going to the field, uh, showing the places of incident, showing the kind of forest—those are all good things that are happening. And so people have found ways of doing it. So if you don't give me advertisement cap, I'll get it from the YouTube subscription. They literally go around asking for subscription and things like that. So they also are under pressure on many things—the—on the subscription really moves. But

I've also been told that YouTube journalism is not so easy. You can't mainly survive on that.

Interviewer: Um, yes.

Participant: A primary source—I do a lot of—for example, my own freelance journalism doesn't give me enough money at all. It's a big thing. That's what I tell some of the very—was something. Yeah. No, no, you don't get that kind of money. But see, I have done, uh, I do—I do pick up assignments now. Documentation with, uh, like last year, I got up—I—I do evaluation studies. I'm a trained development worker. So I do consultancy. I—so people finish their projects, and then they ask us to do an evaluation. It doesn't come so easily because you're also in a very remote area. People in Delhi and other metros find it much easier. And then I'm not found time to build your contacts and network and other things. Those are difficult part of it. But, um, I mean, that's how I have till now managed to survive with some consult. And UNFP wanted to do some documentation of the work—shitty work you—to say what a wonderful work that they're doing. But there also—know, you can't stop us. I remember when Np said that we want to interview a woman Pchat, and how empowered she is. I actually went—she wouldn't open her mouth until her husband tells her. I actually told him, you really want me to write about her empowered woman such? I mean, you spent so much resources. So then, I mean, thankfully that woman who was dealing with me, she said, let's take—I said, can we look at a trans woman? So I do suggest to them the trans woman who has become a serpent, uh, and then sort of write about it. That would be a much more impactful. So it's interesting. Know, if you can sort of, uh, get—so the—they pay good money, uh, it means a lot of—it takes you out of buses. So sometimes I lose out on news in B, but then it keeps my he burning, as they say.

Interviewer: Yes. Yes. Absolutely. And I—I—I only, uh, read your report. That was really, like, interesting that how do this journalist—they take up part-time work.

Participant: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah. It's a tough thing for them as much as it is for me.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: Really bad. In fact, which is why—and I—I really dug really deep into understanding the story because a lot of Ma got threats from—a lot of journalist got thr from the Ma.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: And that's when I sort of proved and proved and look at people doing contractual work for a road. They—you know, whole lot of things happen and journal—they don't like this fact that they saying, like, they do journalism to get contractual works sometime—or most of the time.

Participant: I'm sorry.

Interviewer: And—and, uh, that's actually diluting the whole of journalism.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Ethics in jourm.

Participant: Absolutely.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: And—and also then it makes it easier for the administration of the police to, uh, to—to sort of influence them. They might lose a contract, but with people like us, they will only have to throw us out, you know? They will—you know, they'll not find—I mean, there is no dependency, know, in that sense.

Interviewer: Yes, yes.

Participant: Yes, exactly. There's no dependency. I—I—uh, this is something I—you know, like this concept came while I was interviewing others, this press note journalism. And I—I know, like, you also, like—you—many times during our interview, you spoke about this press note. Is there anything extra you want to add on this press note jourm?

Participant: Because what is—what more do you want? You—we looking for news. We're giving you news, number one. Number two, local journalists are actually—you know, if you see, I have—from one district, I might have 10 journalist contact, and you see their breaking news content is exactly the same.

Interviewer: Exactly.

Participant: So I—and sometimes when journalist argue with the police—

Interviewer: [Laughs]

Participant: So that breaking news is made by the police, and they're expected to run it. So the content is the same. So the news is being actually ruled out, and they have created a WhatsApp group, right, of, uh, local journalists. I have requested so much to the SP, to the people, so please put me also into your group, no, so that whenever there's a breaking news, I also get to know what the breaking news—what news you breaking. But never have they, uh, added me. But I get the news from, uh, local journalist. And, uh, yeah. So—and they actually see who all is running this news. So you have right from the IG to the Tana inch charge who's part of that group.

Interviewer: Oh.

Participant: They keep a track who—who's in—brings out the breaking news.

Interviewer: Okay.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah.

Participant: So breaking new is actually a breaking new by the police. Yeah, of encounters, definitely. Yes. But there might be incidents where, you know, some shika or, you know, case of M station or something like that might be something that they might have dug up and found out and—or some other informer would have given some information.

Interviewer: And how do you see—see your role revolving, uh, in the coming years in these—

Participant: I don't know. I—I did think of doing, uh, you know, videography because people do not have patience to read so much. And also, if you want to U, uh, but I'm not very good at it. I did—you know, if you want to put a wholesome story, a wholesome video story, single-handedly to handle the camera and also the script in terms of, you know, the stories that are there, I did find it very difficult. So, um, that is, uh, one thing I'm struggling with. The second part is that I've always told my, you know, journalist friends that you—if you come across any long-form narrative, uh, stor that can people have interest in, reach out to me. And one, I'll upskill myself in doing long form. The other B is to be able to narrate stories which are—where there are readers who are interested in going beyond just so-cal breaking news. And the third challenge I find is also to be able to say a very, very tough important thing in a very, very concise way, that you also reach out to the audience. I—sadly, if people do not have time doesn't mean that they should not get the news—the right news in the right language, which will—which will

have an impact. So it is for me as a journalist to be able to, uh, be able to put the story across in the most concise, yet impactful. So, yeah, I struggle with that. I do.

Interviewer: All right. All right. Uh, okay. Thank you. Uh, thanks a lot. I have, like, uh, like I have asked all the questions. Is there anything you would like—like to add that, uh, we will discuss?

Participant: Um, when I understood, uh, the concept of news deserts, it is also about people. So when people say that from baser news is not emerging, that is not true. The news is emerging, but the news of a certain kind is emerging. And, uh, the second part is that, um, uh, you know, how do you shape public policy? How do you—if you don't pull out facts and truth, um, then, uh, you create

such a huge gap. Then if you only do, uh, so-called breaking news or news put forward, uh, by what the government want you to put out, then the, uh, when—when—when you were asking me the question of impact of your journalistic work, my impact of journal—all journal should be about bringing out the reality. And then if, um, either policymakers or the government or anybody is willing to read those and say, okay, the reality is something different. Say, for example, if I know that they were looking through huge compensation package and, uh, I—I wish they had been open enough to throw open stories of what exactly has happened to people who got the compensation, um, and then to say, okay, is this really a good comp—is monetary compensation really good? You know, have known and, uh, we spoken about how many—how people have come out of the villages, and they're not able to go back to the villages. People have been killed once they go—go to the village as being Ma informer, uh, sorry, police informer by the Ma by as a police. And it's a very, very pable condition for a local Adasi, you know. They say now you can take the Adasi out of the forest, but you can't take the forest out of the Adas. That person is so troubled, no, that he can't attend to his MAA dance and have the MAA and not be able to—it's a community. And what is it as part of your surrender, as part of your—this thing? What exactly—they were coming up

with a surrender policy. It's so sad. And all they thinking of, know, how to—that person should get a regular job. No, know, if you want to ru people out of it, there are other ways of doing it. What is it that they—so actually to, uh, find ways of informing yourself of what policy asking is, I—I—I seriously feel that there is a gap. By not allowing people to come out with a truthful things, by influencing people to do only reports of what they—they're actually losing out on a very, very—today the society is in a very bad shape now. It's really tattered. It's a beautiful community which have—which—it's—it's really sad. We gone around the place, and I feel terrible about it. How can one's own government is so insensitive to the whole thing? You—and how they could have actually wooed them and not allowed people to go to the Ma—there—we have instance—in fact, there are few stories which still pending, know, from Andra and Telangana, where people have said, enough, we don't want to, you know, side with this one that—we happy to be in this world.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: Voting, selecting our people and—and they sent the message to the Mous, so M actually had to back off, no?

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: And those are stories which need to come out, and how do they do it? Instead of just branding everybody is in—arresting them and killing them make it more—more complicated. That's my, uh, say that if one is able to find ways of, uh, putting across these stories and informing more wider audience, and then yes, it would be the real kind of—I'll feel good about it.

Interviewer: Though—though I'm not like, uh, it's not mainstream practice to, you know, like—like, uh, add my thing, but I would say, like, I—of all the people I—I—I interviewed, I feel, uh, it's not the 100% cost, but the main problem is that business—the financial model around journalism, it's, uh, it—it—it's not viable, uh, enough to, you know, do, uh, the kind of journalism that one would want.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Yes.

Interviewer: Because—

Participant: I don't want disagree with you.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: I mean, I am in—in a very different kind of a position.

Interviewer: Yes.

Participant: Uh, not everybody has that. And which why I feel that local do suffer a lot. But if you have your, um, heart and soul and ethics in the right place for journalism, I—I tell people, know, nobody put a gun against me to say that journalism or no. I can always quit that whole thing. I think people should come with the—with the right things in head.

Interviewer: Yeah, but yeah.

Participant: How much do—

Interviewer: I—I remember my mother—

Participant: Sorry, I lost you.

Interviewer: Go ahead. Go ahead.

Interviewer: I remember my mom talking about this, uh, uh, indigo, uh, revolution. And in the world, you know, like, all these, uh, people were, like, protesting. And, uh, the—she—she used to be a Bengali teacher, and she used to tell me about the stories, like, all these, uh, authors—they used to write Neil Dpon and other—around this indigo farming and, like, trying to tell people about, like, what is going wrong. And she—I remember one—one day he told me that you—like, how this whole thing ended because one German scientist in, uh, Germany, he—he found a way to, um, do—how do you chemically synthesize indigo in land? And that was cheap. And that just, uh, solved the whole problem. And, uh, so I—I look to technology in, like, great I—like—like the way the YouTube and everything has,

like, helped—you know, help to solve the problem. Maybe we could find some other ways to, uh, solve this financial problem.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: Yeah, yeah.

Interviewer: Which is raish—is surviving.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: And one guy I met, he was very—doing interesting job. He was trying to create tokenized impact bonds. So all the—all the stories you write, and somehow it will be able to track the kind of, uh, impact—like, larger impact, uh, it has on the society. And this—this funding agencies like, uh, CSR funding agency or the other agencies, they can buy those bonds from you or—or—or from a deposit.

Participant: Sorry, I didn't get it. So, like, yes, sir, uh, like, this funding agencies, you know, like, they fund you for creating impact. Like, you write story, and you—and because of that story, there is 15 hand pump or you—an investigative journalism, and because of that expose, uh, the total amount of impact is big. And you can tokenize those impact, and it's like a blockchain, and someone, uh, who is funding all these social initiative, they can buy those, uh, uh, impacts. So—because

with investigative journalism, I always felt that the, uh, investment—the time invested and the return, it's—it's not skewed—sked. So—so I always—so I—I feel like I—I'll look up to technology to come up with better financial model.

Participant: Because—

Interviewer: Unless it solve this problem of not paid—get paid for not writing, uh, that needs to be, you know, like, solv—

Participant: Many of the journalist—they didn't say it explicitly, but they told me that people get corrupted because you get more money for not writing.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Participant: Imagine a coder not getting—getting paid for not coding.

Interviewer: Not.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Know.

Participant: So that doesn't help, like—because the coder gets paid because the more amount of coding do—quality of—does—

Interviewer: Journalism is a very interesting thing.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Don't write. Don't write. So we need to have better financial solution.

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Yeah.

Interviewer: So thank you, uh, like—I'm really appreciated all the way—the way you explain the things, and I hope I was helpful.

Participant: Really helpful. It was really helpful.

Interviewer: And this post interview thing, I just wanted to reconfirm that, uh, are you happy for me to use this information you provided for my desertation?

Participant: And for your thesis? Yes.

Interviewer: Yes. And, uh, and as I told you that the, uh, terms and this will be same like 26 and till 26, if you—

Participant: Anything—yeah.

Interviewer: August.

Participant: If I said anything, I can—

Interviewer: I can delete them.

Participant: Okay.

Interviewer: All right. Thank you, XX. I—I'll meet you maybe if I in Bu.

Participant: And—

Interviewer: Yeah, sure.

Participant: Sure.

Interviewer: Sure. Look forward to—

Participant: Yeah.

Interviewer: Please take care. Stay safe.

Participant: Yeah, thank you. Thank you. All the best for your final thesis presentation.

Interviewer: Thank you.

7.7 Appendix- H – Chart

Key Observations:

Increasing Number of Registered Hindi Newspapers: There is a steady increase in the number of registered Hindi newspapers from 1,153 in 2014 to 1,570 in 2020. This suggests that more newspaper licenses are being issued over the years.

Fluctuating Circulation: The circulation of Hindi newspapers shows significant fluctuations, with a peak in 2016 (15,901,663) and a noticeable drop in 2017 and subsequent years, settling around 8 million by 2020.

Negative Correlation: The correlation coefficient between the number of registered Hindi newspapers and their circulation is approximately -0.36. This negative correlation indicates that as the number of registered newspapers increases, the circulation does not proportionally increase and, in some cases, decreases.

Potential Reasons for the Discrepancy: Registered but Non-Operational Newspapers: The increase in the number of registered newspapers without a corresponding rise in circulation suggests that many newspapers might be registered for purposes other than news dissemination. Ghost News paper

This could include:

Government Advertisements: Some entities may register newspapers primarily to qualify for government advertisements, which can be a significant source of revenue, rather than to provide news content.

Comparison of Registered Hindi Newspapers and Their Circulation in Chhattisgarh (2014-2020)

